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A creative visualization of a futuristic cityscape. In the foreground, a large, circular stadium with a green field and tiered seating is visible. Above it, a modern train with purple and white accents travels on an elevated track. To the left, a multi-lane highway curves through the city. In the background, a large cable-stayed bridge spans a body of water. A massive statue of Mahatma Gandhi stands prominently in the center. The sky is a mix of orange, pink, and blue, suggesting sunset or sunrise. The overall scene is a blend of modern infrastructure and historical landmarks.



WOMEN'S RESERVATION
Remove conditions from Bill: rights group
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Purchase price for potato is half of input cost: farmers
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Dinesh Trivedi likely to be envoy to Bangladesh
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Why Noida stir is about more than just wages
It points to a structural issue in labour market
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THE PRIYANSH-CONNOLLY SHOW
Kings retain top spot with emphatic win
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NEARBY



Modi's televised address an act of desperation: CM

KRISHNAGIRI
Prime Minister Narendra Modi's televised address was an act of desperation after suffering a defeat in Parliament during the vote on the Constitution Amendment Bill linked to delimitation, Chief Minister M.K. Stalin has said. » PAGE 8

'404 candidates facing serious criminal cases'

CHENNAI
According to a report, at least 404 candidates contesting the Assembly election have declared that serious criminal cases are pending against them. » PAGE 8

UPSC may defer meeting for DGP empanelment

CHENNAI
The process of appointing a regular DGP may be delayed further, as the UPSC is likely to defer the Empanelment Committee meeting. » PAGE 8

EDUCATIONPLUS » PAGE 7 & 19

Talks today, Trump says as Iran keeps ships out of Strait

U.S. President threatens to destroy civilian infrastructure if Tehran does not accept deal; ceasefire set to expire soon even as stand-off continues

Associated Press
WASHINGTON

U.S. President Donald Trump said on Sunday that U.S. negotiators would head to Pakistan on Monday for talks with Iran, lifting hopes of extending a ceasefire set to expire by Wednesday.

The prospect of talks, which Iran did not immediately confirm, came as ships remain unable to transit the Strait of Hormuz amid threats from Iran and a U.S. blockade on ships heading to and from Iranian ports. The White House said Vice-President J.D. Vance, would lead the U.S. team with envoys Steve Witkoff and Jared Kushner.

Iranian officials earlier on Sunday said that they remained open to negotiation, but held firm that ships would not pass the strait while the U.S. blockade remained in effect. "It is impossible for others to pass through the Strait of Hormuz while we cannot," Iran parliamentary Speaker Mohammed Bagher



Choppy waters: A tanker anchored in the Strait of Hormuz off the coast of Qeshm Island of Iran on Saturday. AP

'India's crude oil imports fell nearly 17% in March'

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Amid the West Asia crisis, India's crude oil imports declined nearly 17% on a year-on-year basis in

March, according to provisional data from the Petroleum Planning and Analysis Cell.

FULL REPORT ON » PAGE 14

Ghalibaf said in an interview on Saturday.

Mr. Trump accused Iran of violating the ceasefire by firing at ships and threatened to destroy civilian infrastructure in Iran, if it

does not take the deal that the U.S. is offering.

CONTINUED ON » PAGE 12
RELATED REPORTS ON » PAGES 12 AND 16

23 killed in explosion at fireworks factory near Virudhunagar in T.N.

S. Sundar
VIRUDHUNAGAR

In one of the deadliest accidents at a fireworks factory in Tamil Nadu in recent times, 23 workers were killed and eight injured in an explosion at Vanaja Fireworks Unit at Kattannarpatti near Virudhunagar on Sunday.

A second explosion at the unit injured 17, including six policemen and four firemen. Rescuers and presspersons who had gathered at the spot narrowly escaped unhurt.

Most victims were charred beyond recognition with many bodies blown away by the impact of the explosion. Firemen were seen collecting mutilated body parts strewn all around the unit. Many bodies were pulled out from the debris after one of the sheds came crashing down on the workers.

The condition of two persons is said to be critical with over 80% burns. All the injured, including a child and five women, were rushed to the Virudhunagar Government Medical College and Hospital.

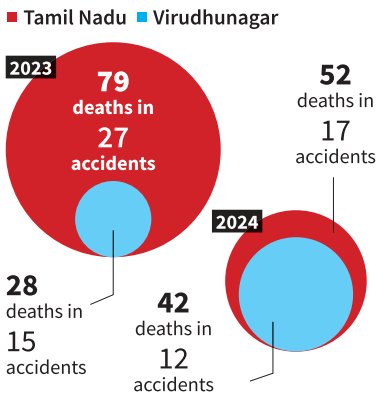
Following instructions from Tamil Nadu Chief Minister M.K. Stalin, Ministers K.K.S.S.R. Ramachandran and Thangam Thennarasu, along with local MLA A.R.R. Srinivasan,

Recurring disasters

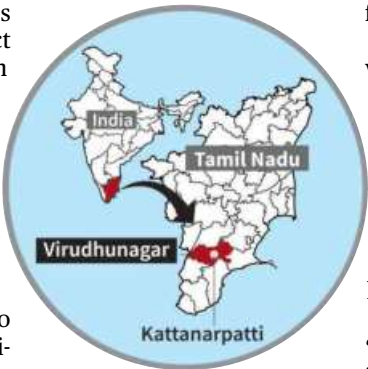
Data show that since 2022, at least 134 people had died and 89 had been injured in firecracker unit accidents in Virudhunagar district of Tamil Nadu



Torn apart: Rescue workers react after a blast during search operations near the firecracker unit in Virudhunagar, Tamil Nadu, on Sunday. G. MOORTHY



At least 21 people were killed in firecracker manufacturing accidents in Virudhunagar between April and August in 2025



from R.R. Nagar.

The Collector said there was a blast around 3.15 p.m. at the shed where chemicals were being mixed.

The fireworks industry is shut on Sundays, but the unit was operating without permission, he said.

'Violated norms'

Some 40 workers, men and women, were busy making firecrackers inside and outside the shed. "All these workers were supposed to be working in their sheds located away from [the site] where the chemical is mixed. But they violated safety norms," the Collector said.

Mr. Sukhaputra said additional medical teams

have been mobilised at the Virudhunagar Hospital. Besides, efforts are on to carry out post-mortem, with experts being brought in from Government Rajaji Hospital in Madurai.

"For any fireworks unit licensed by the District Revenue Officer, only 11 or 12 workers can be employed at any given point of time. That being the case, how can 23 persons die in a single accident," asked a fireworks factory owner. He feared that licensed units would face the brunt of knee-jerk reaction from the officials now.

In licensed units, only four workers are usually allowed in a working shed.

CONTINUED ON » PAGE 12

'Women's reservation was Modi's ruse to implement delimitation to defeat DMK'

P.V. Srividya
KRISHNAGIRI

Prime Minister Narendra Modi needed women's reservation as a ruse to bring in delimitation to defeat the DMK in Tamil Nadu, Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge alleged on Sunday.

Speaking at a joint election campaign with DMK leader and Chief Minister M.K. Stalin in Hosur, Mr. Kharge said the Constitution Amendment Bill had nothing to do with women's reservation, for which a Bill had already been passed with the support of the Opposition in 2023.

'Historic victory'

Terming the defeat of the Constitution Amendment Bill a "historic victory", Mr. Kharge said, "The Women's Reservation Bill was passed into law jointly by all of us in 2023. I ask Mr. Modi - What stopped you from implementing the law for 30 months? He did not implement it because he did not have the need for it. But now, he needs it to defeat the DMK."

Rejecting Mr. Modi's claim on women's empowerment, he said, "The Delimitation Bill had noth-



Sharp attack: Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge addressing a public meeting in Hosur on Sunday. PTI

ing to do with women's reservation. Mr. Modi and his ilk follow Manusmriti, which denies power to Shudras and women."

Criticising Mr. Modi's address, Mr. Kharge said the Opposition alliance was not against women. "We are for democracy; we are for justice and equality," he said.

Urging the people to choose between Mr. Modi and Mr. Stalin and Congress leader Rahul Gandhi, Mr. Kharge said it was because of the people's vote for the DMK and the Congress that they were able to stop the Delimitation Bill.

The Congress president called Mr. Modi a 'liar', and alleged that he had reneged on various promises made in the past decade. "He promised several crore jobs; he promised to

reduce inflation; he promised a war on corruption, and the doubling of farmers' incomes, none of which was fulfilled," Mr. Kharge claimed.

In a show of solidarity within the Secular Progressive Alliance led by the DMK, Mr. Kharge turned to Mr. Stalin and said, "We are there; don't think you are alone. The entire country is standing behind you." Earlier, he shared his affection for, and pride in, the Tamil Nadu Chief Minister (E.V. Ramasamy), Anna (C.N. Annadurai), and leaders who taught India the meaning of dignity, rational thought, and equality."

Five deaths and no arrests as Manipur sees fresh violence

Vijaita Singh
NEW DELHI

Since April 7, Manipur has witnessed five killings, including that of two children, but there have been no arrests in any of the cases so far. The Bishnupur-Churachandpur road has remained blocked for the past 12 days, hindering the National Investigation Agency (NIA)'s investigation into the April 7 killing of two children at Tronglaobi, Bishnupur, a senior government official said.

As the attackers remain unidentified, local people have taken to the streets multiple times in the past week and have clashed with security forces demanding arrest of the attackers, leaving scores of people injured.

The siblings, whose father is a BSF jawan, were sleeping when a "bomb" allegedly launched from a distance of 100-150 metres exploded in their house. Another government official said probe agencies were yet to receive any CCTV footage from the area that could help them identify the attackers as an unexploded device – a galvanised iron pipe with a factory-made rocket tip and wires dangling from its sides – was also recovered near the house.

Manipur group calls for boycott of BJP in State

GUWAHATI

Amid continued violence and a shutdown, an influential organisation in Manipur has announced a boycott of the BJP. It sought a statement from the Chief Minister explaining why the government has been unable to stop the attacks on civilians. » PAGE 12

Meitei civil society groups have accused Kuki-Zo insurgent groups in Churachandpur of being behind the attack.

'Roads blocked'

"No civil supplies are coming to Pherzawl and Churachandpur from Imphal side as the roads remain blocked. The essentials are being routed from Silchar in Assam and Aizawl in Mizoram. Even if Kuki-Zo groups are involved, due to the blockade, the NIA team has not been able to visit Churachandpur for the investigation," the first government official said. On April 10, a BSF jawan was killed in "unprovoked firing by militants" in the Litam area of Ukhrul district.

CONTINUED ON » PAGE 12



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INBRIEF



B. JOTHI RAMALINGAM

CEO flags off marathon to create voter awareness

Chief Electoral Officer Archana Patnaik flagged off a marathon organised by the Voters Association of India in association with the Greater Chennai Corporation on Sunday. About 3,000 people took part in the event aimed at creating awareness to ensure a 100% polling percentage in the April 23 Assembly elections in the State. Greater Chennai Corporation Commissioner and District Election Officer J. Kumaragurubaran, Joint Chief Electoral Officer Srutanjay Narayanan, and Additional District Election Officer Katta Ravi Teja were present on the occasion.

Man hurls glass bottle at TVK candidate's convoy, arrested

Tension prevailed during the campaign of Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK) candidate for Saidapet constituency Arul Prakasam after an empty liquor bottle was hurled at him near the Saidapet court on Sunday. Police said the candidate was walking while canvassing votes in Rangarajapuram, located behind the Saidapet Court. An autorickshaw fitted with loudspeakers was playing TVK campaign songs. Sampath, a car mechanic, who was standing on the second floor of his house, asked the autorickshaw driver to reduce the volume. As the volume was not reduced, Sampath, who was in an inebriated condition, hurled an empty liquor bottle at the TVK members. Following the incident, functionaries from the TVK nabbed Sampath and handed him over to the Kotturpuram Police Station.

Sholinganallur candidates promise piped water supply, infrastructure development

Sitting MLA of the DMK Aravind Ramesh, AIADMK candidate K.P. Kandan, NTK's Jayalakshmi Raman, and TVK's P. Saravanamoorthy promise that all the needs of the constituency will be met

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

With just a few days left for election campaign to end, residents of OMR interacted with candidates contesting in the Assembly polls for the Sholinganallur constituency on Saturday.

Aravind Ramesh, sitting MLA and DMK candidate; K.P. Kandan, former MLA and AIADMK candidate; Jayalakshmi Raman of the NTK, and ECR P. Saravama-moorthy of the TVK hit the pause button on their campaigns to meet the voters, and listed promises and proposals for the constituency, at the 'meet your candidate' event organised by Federation of OMR Residents Associations (FOMRRA).

Mr. Ramesh said that OMR and adjoining areas witnessed exponential growth over the last 10 years, which was one reason why infrastructure could not catch up with the needs of the growing population. "There is no coordination between the CMDA, Greater Chennai Corporation, and Chennai Metro-water. But I am not responsible for that. I am only an



Pitching ideas: AIADMK candidate for Sholinganallur K.P. Kandan interacting with residents at the 'meet your candidate' event organised by FOMRRA on Saturday. R. RAVINDRAN

MLA. If elected for the third time, I will ensure water supply for all homes," he said while replying to questions about when will high rise apartments will get piped water supply.

Mr. Kandan, who was the MLA from 2011 to 2016, said that during his tenure he had laid roads, provided water supply, installed lights in areas that where yet to be merged with the Chennai Corporation. "Garbage clearance was an issue at that time. We got permission to dump garbage at the civic body's dumping yard. The DMK failed to maintain the infrastructure that we had created. If elected, I would ensure better facilities and proper maintenance of those. I will also complete the ECR - OMR link road

from Thoraipakkam," he said.

Ms. Raman, who has completed MCA and worked in the IT sector, said it was her duty to bring better lives for Indians who brought her to politics.

"I will lay roads in such a manner that they will not get damaged for at least 10 years. Similarly, we will provide quality drinking water free of cost to all residents, for which we will clean local water sources." She also said that solid waste management would be decentralised and income generated from its processing. Mr. Saravama-moorthy said he would ensure all the needs of the Constituency are met if elected.

Harsha Koda, co-foun-

der, FOMRRA, said that every election they invited the candidates over so that they can understand the needs of the constituency in a better manner. "The meeting helps clear doubts in the minds of voters, allowing them make an informed decision as to whom to voter for," he said.

On Sunday, FOMRRA members spoke with candidates from Thiruporur Assembly constituency. PMK's K. Balu, an advocate, said he will meet local needs through strong laws. Representing Naam Tamilar Katchi, former Rajya Sabha MP Ambeth Rajan said he will focus on bridging the gap between the modern IT corridor and neglected rural and fishing communities.

TVK's B. Vijayaraj spoke about local issues, including improving connectivity between the city and villages, building multi-specialty hospitals, and resolving patta issues.

VCK's D. Panneerdas, promised to upgrade Navalur and Thazhambur from village panchayats to a single municipality, as it was essential to get State funding for underground sewage system.

In online interface, contestants unveil plans for Villivakkam

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Federation of Anna Nagar Residents' Associations (FOARA) on Sunday hosted online interaction with residents and some of the candidates contesting from the Villivakkam constituency. The candidates presented their five-year vision for the constituency.

Karthik Mohan of the Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK) said that, if elected, he would focus on improving sports infrastructure for the youth. "I promise all parents and children that I will take a strong stance against drug abuse. There should be a diversion. So I will encourage them to participate in sports including our native games. Traffic congestion and healthcare will also be my priorities. We have already addressed many rain-related issues over the past five years," he said, adding his plans for uninterrupted electricity.

Aadhav Arjuna of the Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK) said that he would prioritise equality irrespective of religion, caste, or background. "My voice is with the people. We will rebuild the (government) housing units that are in poor condition in the constituency. There are no proper CCTV cameras there, and from our survey, there is an indication

FOARA secretary raised questions on issues prevailing in the constituency

of high drug abuse. These issues will be addressed alongside safety and security, water and sewer management. Our office will always be accessible to all residents," he promised.

S. Roshini of Naam Tamilar Katchi outlined her plans to bring solar energy into use. She also spoke about the project, 'Vin-naithodum Villivakkam' where she aims to address 16 issues prevalent in the constituency. "We will teach how to use solar power in every single house and work towards preventing drug abuse. We will also focus on Thirai Nidhi Thittam. Among many plans, there will also be skill training provided for better employment opportunities for anyone below the poverty line, with a special focus on women," she said.

Sandhya Vedullapalli, secretary of FOARA, raised questions on enforcement of no-vending zones and prevention of encroachments, tackling drug abuse, electricity infrastructure, and the candidates' view on 'freebies', along with Sukumar Ramaswami, president of FOARA.

State government urges HC to stay order to register FIR in cash-for-jobs case

Mohamed Imranullah S.
CHENNAI

The Tamil Nadu government has urged the Madras High Court to stay its February 20, 2026 order directing the Directorate of Vigilance and Anti-Corruption (DVAC) to register a First Information Report (FIR) over an alleged cash-for-jobs scam in the Municipal Administration and Water Supply (MAWS) Department, led by Minister K.N. Nehru.

The stay petition, filed along with a review plea,

has been listed for hearing before the first Division Bench of Chief Justice Sushrut Arvind Dharmadhikari and Justice G. Arul Murugan on Monday. However, the judges may adjourn the hearing by a day or two, since Advocate General (A-G) P.S. Raman had informed the court about his unavailability on Monday.

On Thursday (April 16), the A-G had told the Bench that the review petition filed by the government for setting aside the February 20 order and the interim

stay application, too, had been numbered, and would be listed on Monday, but he won't be in the city to argue the matter since he was going to New Delhi for attending a conference of Advocates General.

The judges accepted his request for a short accommodation, and said formal orders regarding the next date of hearing would be passed in the presence of the other advocates when the review plea gets listed on Monday. The court had directed the DVAC to regis-



The High Court had said a 232-page dossier shared by the ED with the State police contained solid material to arrive at a prima facie conclusion of several crores of rupees having changed hands.

ter the FIR based on a writ petition filed by AIADMK Rajya Sabha member I.S. Inbadurai.

The High Court had said a 232-page dossier shared by the Directorate of Enforcement (ED) with the State

The court had directed the DVAC to register the FIR over the alleged scam in MAWS Department led by Minister K.N. Nehru

police contained solid material to arrive at a prima facie conclusion of several crores of rupees having changed hands through Hawala transactions for filling 2,538 posts of Assistant Engineers, Junior Engineers, and Town Planning

Officers, and hence, the police were obligated to register an FIR.

'Large-scale corruption' "The details shared and the available materials reveal that those candidates got selected pursuant to the alleged transactions, and when a large-scale corruption is stated to have happened, involving several hundred crores of rupees, we find that the source material is sufficient enough disclosing the commission of a cognisable offence for the pur-

pose of registering a case," the court had said.

After waiting for a few days pursuant to the order, Mr. Inbadurai filed a contempt of court petition, through senior counsel V. Raghavachari, accusing the DVAC of not having filed the FIR despite a specific instruction to register it "forthwith". Even as the proceedings in the contempt plea are pending, the State government has approached the court with a plea to review the judgment and set aside the February 20 order.



Dignitaries at the book launch of Kaatrukku Enna Veli in the city on Sunday. J. JOHAN SATHYADAS

Autobiography of asthma specialist Sridharan launched

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The autobiography of asthma and allergy specialist Sridharan titled Kaatrukku Enna Veli was launched here on Sunday by director of Cardiothoracic surgery of SIMS Hospital, Vadapalani V. V. Bashi at the Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan. The first copy of the book was received by Ramco Cements CEO A. V. Dharmakrishnan. Speaking after releasing the book, Dr. Bashi said that he knew Dr. Sridharan for over 30 years now and that they have had several common patients. Dr. Sridhar said that Dr. Bashi was an amazing cardio thoracic surgeon. Musician Bharadwaj, whose tunes have been used by the doctor to create awareness about asthma, said the way Dr. Sridharan cared for patients was simply unparalleled. Orator Marabin Maindhan Muthiayya, and Tiruppur Krishnan, Editor, Amudasurabi magazine, also spoke.

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INBRIEF



Foundation opens dementia care centre in Pallikaranai

The Dementia Care Foundation (TDCF) inaugurated a Daycare and Experiential Centre at Pallikaranai in the city, expanding access to structured support for persons living with dementia. Established in association with the Asan Memorial College of Arts & Science, the facility seeks to integrate clinical care with community engagement. The inaugural programme, titled “Meet De(Me)ntia for Coffee,” brought together clinicians, caregivers and academicians, with an emphasis on experiential understanding. The participants engaged in cognitive stimulation activities designed to foster conversation and emotional connection. Speaking on the occasion, Gayathri Ananthakrishnan, founder, TDCF, underscored the importance of moving beyond stigma and recognise personhood in dementia care. R. Seshasayee, Chairman, Asian Paints and Chief Guest, highlighted the role of community-led initiatives in addressing the growing burden of dementia.

Text & Context and Science

Weekday features on *The Hindu* epaper (epaper. thehindu.com) carries explainers, special articles and quizzes. In the latest issue (April 20, Monday), the following explainers are available:

- On delimitation and Parliament seats newsth.live/delimitationbill
 - Gene drives and malaria: how altered mosquitoes could reshape disease control newsth.live/malaria
- You can use your smartphone’s inbuilt features to access this article. If it’s an Android phone, use Google Lens to read and tap the url to access the article. If it’s an iPhone, use Live Text on camera to do the same.

DMK releases ‘super six’ election promises for city’s development

Completing Metro Rail extension project and stormwater drain works by 2028, and introducing 1,000 new mini-buses are among the promises

Aloysius Xavier Lopez
CHENNAI

The DMK on Sunday announced ‘Chennai Super Six,’ a list of election promises for the civic infrastructure growth, development and residents’ welfare in Assembly constituencies of Chennai.

Releasing the manifesto on Sunday, Chief Minister M.K. Stalin said: “If it is Chennai’s development, it is the DMK. The DMK has played the greatest role in infrastructure development of Chennai. These promises will ensure growth and development of Chennai.”

According to the manifesto, the DMK has promised to complete Metro Rail extension work by 2028 across the city. If the DMK is elected to power again, the State government will introduce 1,000 new mini-buses to connect bus stands, metro stations, railway stations with each of the interior roads in the city.

Similar to the proposed corridor connecting Ennore with Poonjeri, the State government will implement ten new projects to ease traffic congestion by 2027. Work on stormwater drains will be completed by 2028 while sewer



Capital focus: Chief Minister M.K. Stalin releasing the party's manifesto for Chennai on Sunday. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

network will be completed by 2027. Projects for well-designed roads, footpaths, trees and toilets will be implemented by 2029.

In a bid to prevent dog bite cases, the number of veterinary surgeons and dog catchers will be increased three-fold.

Residential areas without Metrowater supply will get RO purified water, while drinking water supply will be ensured at regular intervals in residential areas with Metrowater connection. Streetlights with better technology will be installed in all roads. TNUHDB tenements will

get public infrastructure facilities with government funding through residents’ welfare association of women.

The State government will develop a cultural centre of world-class standards for art, music and literary events. It will also develop a world-class Centre for Artificial Intelligence, Animation, Visual Effects, Gaming and Immersive Technologies with ₹10,000 crore investment, providing 20,000 highly skilled jobs. A global talent gateway will be developed with world-class infrastructure in the city.

Two persons die while cleaning wastewater tank near Avadi

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Two persons who were engaged in cleaning a wastewater tank at an onion export unit in Pandeeswaram near Avadi were killed after they inhaled poisonous gases.

Avadi police said Natraj was operating an onion drying and export unit-cum-warehouse in Pandeswaram on the Arakkambakkam Road near Avadi.

In this facility, onions are washed, sliced, mechanically dried, and packaged into pouches for export to various countries,

The two inhaled poisonous gases while cleaning the tank and collapsed

including Singapore and Malaysia. The wastewater generated from washing the onions is collected and stored in a 15-foot-deep tank located in the premises.

On Sunday, the company engaged two persons Vijay, 34, and Arun, 30, both residents of Kalaingar Nagar in Pandeswaram, for regular cleaning of the vegetable wastewater tank.

The duo inhaled the poisonous gases while cleaning the tank and collapsed.

On being alerted about the accident, the Muthapudupet police rushed to the facility and sent the bodies to the Kilpauk Government Hospital for a post mortem.

Officials from the Fire and Rescue Services, Avadi, forensic experts, revenue and electricity department officials are conducting an inquiry into the cause of the accident.

Meanwhile, the Muthapudupet police have filed a case against Natraj, the owner of the warehouse.

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Shah holds roadshow in Mylapore

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

In the evening of a hot sweltering weekend, crowds grew as Union Minister for Home Affairs and Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) leader Amit Shah began his roadshow in Mylapore, campaigning for the NDA candidates contesting the upcoming Assembly election.

At 7.00 p.m. on Sunday, Mr. Shah rode on the campaign vehicle waving to people chanting ‘Bharat Mata Ki Jai’. Mylapore constituency BJP candidate Tamilisai Soundararajan, Thousand Lights AIADMK candidate B. Valarmathi, and Velachery AIADMK candidate M.K. Ashok also waved to the crowd near Kapaleeshwar Temple.

The restless crowd adorned in BJP shawls, AIADMK flags and lotus



Amit Shah campaigning with Mylapore constituency candidate Tamilisai Soundararajan, Thousand Lights candidate B. Valarmathi and Union Minister Piyush Goyal in Mylapore on Sunday. R. RAGU

fans grew enthusiastic when Mr. Shah threw back the flowers. Union Minister of Commerce and Industry Piyush Goyal also accompanied them.

Arriving at 3.00 p.m., Arasi (name changed) from Madhavaram came to just see the man from “Delhi”. “I have seen the development of the party and don’t think I would get another opportunity to see

them,” she said. She along with her friends from the area had come to see the Home Minister. With Karagattam, Mayilattam, Nathasawarm, Bharatnatyam and drums welcoming the vehicle, the public cheered as they moved forward.

While the NTK and TVK have fielded Brahmin candidates in Mylapore, the BJP has not. Vasantha Sridharan, a resident of

Mylapore noted that she was disappointed that a Brahmin candidate was not fielded by the BJP. “We will vote for development, which Tamilisai will bring as she is well read and very educated. Slowly and hopefully changes can be made,” she said.

Echoing her thoughts, another resident from Mylapore said that it would have been good for Mylapore, if changes can be brought in slowly. “Right now, development is important and especially the issues around alcohol must be addressed, which the BJP has been firm on,” he said. However, a couple of other residents had hoped that someone like Uma Anandan (councillor) might have been chosen. “Someone who knows the locality would have been a good option. Caste is not a factor,” said Meera Gopal Rao, resident of Mylapore.

Vote only for those who listen to your grievances, says G.K. Vasan

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Tamil Maanila Congress (Moopanar) president G. K. Vasan on Sunday said that a candidate need not be popular, but in the electoral fray, people should think and vote whether the candidate would listen to their grievances, understand, and resolve them.

Canvassing votes for PMK treasurer M. Thilagabama, who is the NDA’s nominee for the Perambur Assembly segment, Mr. Vasan said, “With the support of both the Union government and the next govern-



G.K. Vasan campaigning for PMK's Perambur candidate M. Thilagabama on Sunday. B. JOTHI RAMALINGAM

ment led by AIADMK general secretary Edappadi K. Palaniswami, Perambur will witness all-round de-

velopment,” he said. Highlighting several issues in Perambur, including encroachment of roads, flooding during the rainy season, and problems associated with the Kodungaiyur dump yard, Mr. Vasan said the DMK government had not taken steps to resolve the issues and appealed to the people to support Ms. Thilagabama, whom he said would take up all the issues in Perambur in the Assembly. Later, Mr. Vasan also canvassed votes for NDA nominees in Thiru. Vi. Ka Nagar and Saidapet constituencies.


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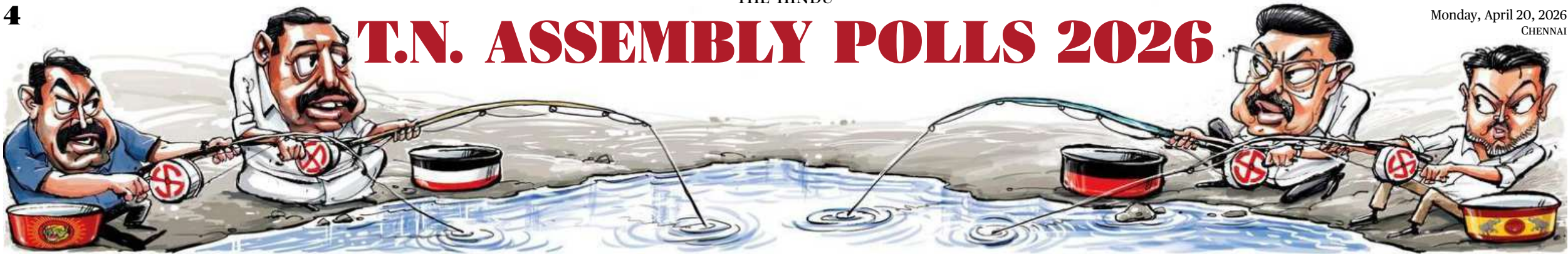
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Ver Pattru: caught between one’s roots and student politics

B. Kolappan
CHENNAI

In Tamil Nadu, beneath impressive development indicators and a long history of social reform, cinema continues to exert a powerful influence on public life. For many actors, politics remains an alluring second act, a phenomenon dating back to M.G. Ramachandran, who remained electorally unseated for 13 years until his death. Not all have succeeded. Yet, actors like Vijay loom large, threatening the entrenched political status quo in the State.

Their entry has inevitably revived debates about the absence of political activity in educational institutions. The Dravidian movement, which once benefited immensely from a groundswell of student support, appears – at least in retrospect – to have turned a blind eye to this decline. Today, most colleges and universities have shut their doors to politics. The proliferation of engineering colleges, where students are driven primarily by the goal of securing placements through campus interviews, has left little time for extracurricular engagement, let alone political involvement.

It is here that *Ver Pattru* – curiously translated as Poison Roots – offers a glimpse into an earlier, more vibrant era of campus politics. This was a time marked by active student participation and the presence of political groups such as the Congress, the Communists, and the Dravidar Kazhagam.

Dominated by autobiographical elements, the novel is set in Kumbakonam and Chidambaram. Its author, Indira Parthasarathy, a native of Kumbakonam, studied at the Government Arts College there, and later at Annamalai University. It was a period when the humanities and pure sciences were taught with vigour by distinguished teachers. Kesavan, the protagonist, is caught between his roots as a Vaishnavite Brahmin and his newfound political awakening through communism.

“Comrade, I need to discuss an important issue with you,” said Murugesan, when he saw Kesavan. Murugesan is a committed communist who openly identifies as one. Kesavan envies Murugesan, who casually uses terms such as “proletariat,” “bourgeoisie,” and “Fourth International.” The novel spans the period from 1946 to 1952.

Murugesan’s complaint is that Kesavan remained silent when Professor Subramania Iyer criticised the Soviet Union. “Russia remains a symbol of hope for the world proletariat. Can he criticise that country? But for Joseph Stalin, Hitler would have swallowed the world.” He is firm in his belief that economic empowerment and political awakening would eventually render social reform unnecessary. He persuades Kesavan to contest the college union elections. There is a candidate from the Dravidar Kazhagam, besides Kittu, a student Congress leader. Kittu asks Kesavan to withdraw his nomination, arguing that his presence would split the Brahmin vote and pave the way for Chokkalingam. His prediction proves correct – Chokkalingam wins. Murugesan blames Kesavan, accusing him of failing to meet voters individually and seek their support. When Kesavan reminds him of his earlier reluctance to contest, Murugesan says they will manage better in the next election. Kesavan, however, remains firm in his decision not to contest. “How can you withdraw like a coward after reading Marx and Engels?” Kesavan responds, “Marx and Engels never contested elections.”

Ultimately, Kesavan proves unfit for politics. He completes his M.A. in Tamil from Annamalai University, but finds it difficult to secure a job. When he finally manages to join a college, Indira Parthasarathy writes, “Kesavan got a job because he is a Brahmin by birth. Because he is an Iyengar. Because he is the son of Nadathur Iyengar. Because he knows Gayatri and *Perumal Thirumozhi*.”

AIADMK looks to defend Melur and Usilampatti, its southern strongholds

Intra-party conflicts, which eroded the party’s core base in the southern districts, do not have much impact on these two constituencies in Madurai; while the AIADMK has won from the Melur Assembly segment five times consecutively since 2001, Usilampatti has rarely elected a DMK candidate

Udhav Naig
CHENNAI

Despite the Edappadi K. Palaniswami-led AIADMK seemingly witnessing an erosion of the party’s core base since 2017 in the southern districts due to intra-party conflicts, it does not appear to have had much impact on constituencies such as Melur and Usilampatti in Madurai, considered the party’s fortress.

The AIADMK has won from the Melur Assembly segment five times consecutively since 2001.

This time, incumbent MLA Periyapullan, alias P. Selvam, is contesting against former Congress Kancheepuram MP, P. Viswanathan, who belongs to the Scheduled Caste.

While the Tamilaga Vetti Kazhagam (TVK) and the Naam Tamilar Katchi (NTK) are expected to make their presence felt, locals expect Sonia Gandhi, fielded by V.K. Sasikala of the All India Puratchi Thalaivar Makkal Munnetra Kazhagam, to make a significant impact, especially among the sizeable Kallar population.

When *The Hindu* went to the campaigns of the



Gaining ground: Congress candidate for Melur constituency P. Viswanathan, along with DMK leader K. Tamilarasan, campaigning at Kottakudi. G. MOORTHY

Congress in Kottakudi and the AIADMK in Vellaripatti, a few things became clear. The contest is always between two significant communities in Melur – Mutharayars and Kallars – according to party men from both sides. The DMK and the AIADMK fronts depend on time-tested electioneering methods, reaching out to older voters, while most of the “young voters” reportedly lean towards the TVK or the NTK.

AIADMK’s popular former MLA, R. Samy – before Mr. Selvam was given

the ticket in 2016 – hailed from the Kallar community. In contrast, the genial Congress candidate, Mr. Viswanathan, faced opposition from local party men for being an “outsider”. A local Congress district office-bearer said the party had made a costly mistake by giving the ticket to an “outsider”, a term also used by a DMK office-bearer, who was one of the organisers of the campaign in Kottakudi.

“Had the Congress fielded a Kallar candidate, they could have given the

AIADMK a run for their money... especially since former AIADMK MLA K. Tamilarasan joined the DMK only last month, in the presence of Minister P. Moorthy (local strongman). There is a resentment among the Kallars that they have been sidelined by the AIADMK. They now have to rely on Mr. Moorthy’s ability to win this seat,” he said.

Caste consciousness

The voters in the constituency are highly “caste conscious”, always trying

‘No friend or foe in politics; it is about seizing the moment’

Over 90% of DMDK district secretaries wanted to align with DMK, says Virudhunagar candidate Vijaya Prabhakaran, whose father, late party founder Vijayakant, was a strong critic of the DMK

INTERVIEW

V. Vijaya Prabhakaran

M. Kalyanaraman

V. Vijaya Prabhakaran, the DMDK candidate in Virudhunagar Assembly constituency, who lost the 2024 Lok Sabha election by a narrow margin, hopes to emerge victorious this time. In an interview with *The Hindu*, the son of late actor-politician Vijayakant says the decision to join the DMK alliance was taken because the DMDK’s rank and file wanted it. Edited excerpts:

You did very well in the 2024 Lok Sabha polls when the AIADMK front you were a part of performed poorly elsewhere. How did that happen?

Virudhunagar has always been a stronghold of the DMDK. We won in 2011 here. The 2024 elections were held a few months after my father passed away. People showed their sympathy and love towards him. The alliance was also strong.

Why do you think you will be able to repeat the performance in a different alliance? How does it feel that your then opponent Manickam Tagore is working for you now?

People’s love is still there.



We have a presence in every booth. Last time, I lost by 4,000 votes. If we had got one additional vote per booth, I would have won. Life is faith. I am creating my own aura here. I have jumped into the fray with full faith.

Vijayakant always campaigned on an anti-DMK plank. Your mother had also criticised them strongly in the past...

When Captain (Vijayakant) started the party, the DMK was in power. He, therefore, had to take an anti-DMK plank. Now, [actor C. Joseph] Vijay has started a party and he is criticising the DMK only for that reason. But if you remember, it was never personal. Captain always referred to Mr. Karunanidhi (former Chief Minister) as Kalaigarn. He never called him by name. He always had respect for him. Also, Captain had

vehemently opposed Jayalithaa in the Assembly after aligning with the AIADMK.

Ideology will help create a strong party. But politics is about strategy and tactics. In politics, there are no permanent enemies or friends.

But will your cadre accept the alliance? Won’t your voters be put off by it?

The decision to go with the DMK was taken after consulting with [the DMDK’s] rank and file. More than 90% of the district secretaries wanted to align with the DMK. Our presence benefited both the AIADMK and the BJP. But they didn’t do much for us. We didn’t get any representation at the Centre or in the State. See, our party workers are poor people. They would want to hold positions at their level too. But they didn’t get any recognition.

Post election season, the going gets tough for look-alike artistes

Sahana Mira S.
CHENNAI

“It is true that we have opportunities during the election campaign, but for the rest of the year, we are mostly tossed aside like curry leaves, with very few works coming our way,” says Kumar from Namakkal, known by everyone in his neighbourhood as Vijaykanth Kumar, who, since 1991, has been mirroring DMDK founder Vijayakant at poll campaigns.

“This is our full-time job, and post the election season, we usually turn to temple festivals, carnivals, and weddings. That sustains us for six months. Once, an IT company invited us to surprise their employees, but work is not much beyond that,” says Mr. Kumar, adding that he has earned pretty well this election campaign, compared to the previous ones.

In Chennai, M.G. Antony gets ready to emulate former Chief Minister M.G. Ramachandran (MGR), adding the final touch of the signature fur cap. He has long worn MGR’s dress and style, and sings too, at political campaigns. He has also transformed into former Chief Minister M. Karunanidhi. “After the demise of former Chief Minister Jayalithaa, things have not been the same for artistes like me. She always encouraged us and gave us opportunities all year round,” adds Mr. Antony.

Meanwhile, for women artistes, the competition is intense when it comes to look-alikes of Jayalithaa. V. Ramya, a Salem-based artiste, has spent 13 years in the field, doing her version of the former leader.



M.G. Antony, one of the artistes, dressed up as former Chief Minister M.G. Ramachandran

“Even though I manage to bring out at least a 50% resemblance of Amma (Jayalithaa), I have not received many opportunities this election, because I quote my charges, including bus fares. Organisers easily opt for others who may not even resemble her as closely but charge less. That is not the point of deploying look-alikes,” she says.

She adds that, at times, even agreed payments fail to materialise fully. But something that gnaws at her – and fellow women artistes in particular – is the limited washroom facilities as they walk street after street during campaigns.

S. Ammu, a Chennai-based artiste, who also dresses up as Jayalithaa, echoes the concern. “I make it a point not to drink water, even during long campaign hours, as there are no proper sanitation facilities in all the places we visit across the State. We continue with this work because we genuinely enjoy it, and after all, this is the only livelihood we know,” she adds. “There is a lot of campaigns booked for me in Chennai this time. I recently participated in one at Royapuram,” Ms. Ammu adds.



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The fire was not able to be contained due to a depository of biomass, officials say.

Massive fire destroys over 100 hectares of forest

The Hindu Bureau
UDHAGAMANDALAM

More than 100 hectares of forest is estimated to have been destroyed after a massive wildfire broke out in the Pykara Forest Range in Udhagamandalam about five days ago.

The fire could not be brought under control due to the presence of a large depository of biomass comprising exotic undergrowth, officials said. Over hundred personnel from the Forest Department in the Nilgiris and neighbouring Forest Divisions of Erode, Salem and Coimbatore and fire and rescue service personnel have been deployed since Friday in an attempt to control the blaze.

The blaze also led to the closure of the Pykara Boat House on Sunday.

Officials said that they were confident of extinguishing the blaze in the next 24 hours.

BJP defeated women's quota, says Venugopal

The AICC general secretary says that the legislation for 33% reservation for women had been passed in 2023 and it was notified three days ago

The Hindu Bureau
COIMBATORE

All India Congress Committee general secretary K.C. Venugopal said that it is the BJP that defeated [the objective of] "women's reservation" in the country. He campaigned for V. Srinithi, the Congress candidate from Singanallur Assembly constituency in Coimbatore, on Sunday.

Stating that the INDIA bloc is completely in support of women's reservation, Mr. Venugopal pointed out that the legislation for 33% reservation for women was passed in 2023 and it was notified three days ago.

"Please implement it immediately. But their agenda to reduce seats of Tamil Nadu, Kerala, Odisha and more States [by linking it to delimitation] has been defeated. We defeated the Delimitation Bill [Constitution (131st Amendment) Bill, 2026]. But, the BJP defeated women's reservation



Clarifying party's stand: K.C. Venugopal, while campaigning for Congress candidate V. Srinithi, said that INDIA bloc supports women's reservation. SIVA SARAVANAN S.



We defeated the Delimitation Bill [Constitution (131st Amendment) Bill, 2026]. But, the BJP defeated women's reservation

K.C. VENUGOPAL
AICC general secretary

and deliver a *bhashan* (speech) like this," the MP from Kerala asked, countering Mr. Modi's claims on women's reservation and related topics in the public address in Coimbatore on Saturday.

Responding to Mr. Modi's remark in his address to the nation, in which he accused the Opposition of committing a foeticide of the idea of women's representation, Mr. Venugopal said: "He can say anything. But the opposition com-

pletely stopped his ill-motive to divide the country in the name of regional issues. Our motive is very clear - implement women's reservation immediately".

The government should have called for an all-party meeting for consensus before holding the Parliament session on the Constitution (131st Amendment) Bill, he said.

"They [NDA] thought that they could bulldoze this Bill. Tamil Nadu is going for an election and all MPs are campaigning here. What was the urgency of calling for the session two days in between the election. This was clearly their ill-motive to disrupt States like Tamil Nadu. We have already defeated that and the people of Tamil Nadu will again give a clear reply to Mr. Modi," Mr. Venugopal said.

Free transport arranged for senior citizens on polling day

CHENNAI: Free transport facilities have been arranged for persons with disabilities and senior citizens in Chennai district to enable them to cast their vote in person on polling day on April 23.

Eligible voters can avail themselves of the service by registering through the Saksham app or by contacting the district helpline 1950 or the control room at 1800-425-7012, according to a release.

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Open Tender Number	Description of the item	Tender Value	Date of Tender Closing Date & Time
2026476212189	Works contract of "Comprehensive Annual Maintenance Contract (CAMC) for one no. of Automatic Spring Paint booth with oven and one no. of Phosphating Plant make "Crescent Technologies" bearing Inv.Nos. 7518 & 7519 available in Shop-15 ("L" shed, Spring Shop) for a period of 3 years".	Rs.86,73,000/-	02.05.2026 up to 12.00 Hours

Hindi version of the above advertisement is available in the <http://icf.indianrailways.gov.in/>
Dy. Chief Mechanical Engineer / Plant

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customercare@thehindu.co.in

Scan the QR code to register your feedback

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FRONTLINE SPORTSTAR you@hinduworld THE HINDU

INTEGRAL COACH FACTORY, CHENNAI - 38

EMPANELMENT OF ADVERTISING AGENCIES

Notification No. AP/15/Empanelment of Advtg. Agencies Dt. 17/04/2026

Application are invited from INS accredited and reputed Advertising Agencies for empanelment in Integral Coach Factory, Chennai for a period of two years from the date of empanelment.

Scope of Work: Release of Display / Tender Advertisements in the print Media within the stipulated time, creative artwork and other PR related works.

Application format, detailed terms and condition can be downloaded from: www.icf.indianrailways.gov.in. Filled applications with the requisite documents and the receipt for non-refundable application fee of Rs.5,900/- (Rs.5,000+18% GST), in a sealed cover addressed to the **Chief Public Relations Officer / ICF, Office of the General Manager, 1st Floor, Integral Coach Factory, Chennai - 600 038**, Should be dropped in the box kept in the General Manager's Office / ICF, from 11.00 hrs. on 24.04.2026 to 11.00 hrs. on 12.05.2026 after which the box will be closed.

CHIEF PUBLIC RELATIONS OFFICER

ICF HOSPITAL, CHENNAI - 600 038.

NOTIFICATION

No.MD/ICF/CASE TO CASE Dt. 16-04-2026
ENGAGEMENT OF SPECIALIST DOCTORS ON CASE TO CASE BASIS

Applications are invited from eligible candidates for engagement of Specialist Doctors on the following fields on Case to Case basis at ICF Hospital, Chennai - 600 038.

S.N.	Specialty	Area of special interest / Subspecialty
1	Neurology	Neurologist
2	Cardiology	Cardiologist
3	Endocrinology	Endocrinologist
4	Rheumatology	Rheumatologist
5	Oncology	Medical Oncologist
6	Radiology	Radiologist for Ultra Sound Scanning
7	Urology	Urologist
8	Psychiatry	Psychiatrist

The applications should be filled in on an A4 Size Paper, in the prescribed format and complete with all the requisite enclosures.

Details of advertisement, application form and other details are available on Integral Coach Factory website at link- <https://icf.indianrailways.gov.in>

Applications may be downloaded from the website or may be collected from PCMO's office and should submit application form duly filled in and signed along with self attested copies of all the requisite documents in the office of Principal Chief Medical Officer, ICF Hospital, Chennai 600 038 on or before **14th MAY 2026**. (The above requirement of case to case consultants may vary if and when regular IRHS specialists are available).

PRINCIPAL CHIEF MEDICAL OFFICER, ICF HOSPITAL / Chennai - 600 038.

Contact No.044 26146640, 26146633

OBITUARY & REMEMBRANCE

DEATH

Mr. G.DINAKAR Chief Manager (Retd.) Bank of India passed away on 18th April. Final rites will be performed on 20th April 9 am at his residence. Contact: +91 8754551276

DEATH

Mr. A.P. MURTHY (A) PRIYA MURTHY
Aged 77 years
(Founder, Priya Cultural Academy)
Passed away on 19.04.2026 at 12:00 noon at his residence in Pallikaralai.
Funeral on 20.04.2026 at 9:00 AM (residence), followed by cremation at Besant Nagar Crematorium at 11:00 AM.
Deeply mourned by **Family members and relatives.**
Contact: 9566033880

DEATH

Mr. R.V. RAMARAJ, (Retd)
Reserve Bank of India
Founder of NAMBI HOME NEEDS
breathed his last at 8.30am. on 19/04/2026.
His last rites will be performed at his residence, above Nambi Home Needs 57, Habibullah Rd,T. Nagar, Chennai-17, at around 3.00p.m. on 20/04/2026
Lovingly Nambi & Ilango - Sons Nirmal Sivaraj - daughter

DEATH

Mr. R. JAYALAKSHMI (84)
Former TNEB, attained the Lotus feet of Swami on 17.04.2026 in Chennai.
—Survived by—
Husband: T. R. Krishnamurthy (Former Wheels India Ltd.),
Sons: K. Ramamurthy, K. Keerthivasan,
Daughters-in-law: R. Anuradha, K. R. Raji,
Granddaughter: R. Ananya and Grandson: K. Tarun.

DEATH ANNIVERSARIES

4th ANNIVERSARY REMEMBRANCE

Sri. T. RAMA RAO
Film Director / Producer / Distributor / Chairman - Madras Hydraulic Hose Pvt Ltd.
(12.11.1938 - 20.04.2022)
"The Man who rose and stood tall for his integrity, sincerity and hard work will be cherished and remembered forever in our hearts"
"We will strive to live up to the values that you have instilled in all of us and Progress in the Path shown by you. We will always feel your presence through your blessings."
Family, Friends and Relatives

DEATH

Dr. JACOB ABRAHAM (94)
05.05.1931 - 19.04.2026
Noted neurosurgeon and former Medical Superintendent and Head of the Department of Neurological Sciences, CMC Vellore, passed away in Chennai. He is survived by his wife Susan Abraham (Ammu), siblings, in-laws numerous nieces and nephews and generations of students.
Viewing at his residence No. 10, 15th Avenue, Harrington Road between 7 and 9:30 am on 20.4.2026.
Funeral service will be held at Mar Thoma Syrian Church , Chetpet, at 10 am on 20.4.2026, followed by the burial at Kilpauk Cemetery, Chennai.

DEATH ANNIVERSARIES

5th ANNIVERSARY
26.08.1930 - 14.05.2021
Retd. Chief Finger Print Examiner Southern Railways
Fondly remembered by Family
G. Balaji : 9840613579
G. Mahendra : 8903564579

DEATH ANNIVERSARIES

Eighth Year Anniversary
Mrs. Velammal Kodeswaran
Lovingly Remembered by Family and Friends

DEATH ANNIVERSARIES

20th ANNIVERSARY
20th April 2026
Shri.K.R.D. PRASAD
B.Tech. M.S.I.A. (CMU)
"You still live in our hearts"
Trustees & Staff
K.R.D. Prasad Trust

DEATH ANNIVERSARIES

1st ANNIVERSARY
My beloved mother left us on this day 20.04.2025.
Smt. G. Lakshmi Narasamba
DOB: 16.09.1944 - 20.04.2025
W/o. Shri G.Suryanarayana Garu,
Asst. Exe. Engr / S.O. E&M, Madras Port Trust
Deeply missing you AMMA always. By everloving children
Ph: 2224 4077

DEATH ANNIVERSARIES

RESPECTFUL HOMAGE ON THE SEVENTH YEAR ANNIVERSARY
SRI. B.PRAKASH CHAND DUGAR S/O. LATE BHERUDANJI DUGAR
EXPIRED : 20.04.2019
Memories spent with you are precious and infinite wealth
You have been the pillar and strength of our lives
You will be always alive in our thoughts
Your legacy lives on in every value you taught us.
Inserted by:-
Wife, Brothers, Daughters, Sons-in-law, Sons, Daughter-in-law, Grand Daughter
M/s. BHERUDAN DUGAR FINANCE LIMITED

DEATH ANNIVERSARIES

5th THITHI REMEMBRANCE (20.04.2026)
A.S.GAJARAJ
26.08.1930 - 14.05.2021
Retd. Chief Finger Print Examiner Southern Railways
Fondly remembered by Family
G. Balaji : 9840613579
G. Mahendra : 8903564579

BIRTHDAY REMEMBRANCE

Post-Platinum-Aquamarine (88) Birth Anniversary
Before I formed you in the womb, I knew you.
- Jeremiah 1 : 5
Mary Mathew
20.04.1938
Celebrating the spiritually prosperous and exemplary life of our beloved sister Mema, on her birth anniversary today.
Remembering with thanksgiving
Elma & family; Praveen & Thampi; Nena & family; Ms. A. Thomas & family; Saji, Reji, Vijji & family

DEATH ANNIVERSARIES

Ruby (40) Anniversary
Ninan Thomas
Azhikkakathu House, Ayroor
20.04.1986
Tamil Nadu Government Collegiate Services
Remembering with ardent adoration
Elma & family; Nena & family; Praveen & Thampi; Ms. A. Thomas & family; Saji, Reji, Vijji & family

IN MEMORY OF YOUR LOVED ONES
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John J. Kennedy

For decades, higher education across the globe sold a fairly standard dream: secure admission to a prestigious institution, earn a marketable degree, and move smoothly into employment. Rankings, brand value, and placement statistics were treated as proxies for success.

However, the *Annual Student Quest Report 2025* released by the International College and Career Counselling (IC3) Institute suggests that today's students, across regions and socio-economic contexts, appear to be recalibrating what they expect from higher education and are prioritising well-being, safety, purpose, and long-term relevance over institutional prestige.

This shift reflects a generation coming of age amid overlapping crises: a pandemic that exposed mental health fragilities, economic uncertainty that unsettled linear career paths, rapid technological change that renders skills obsolete faster than degrees can certify them, and a global climate of anxiety shaped by conflict, climate change, and political instability.

In such a context, it is hardly surprising that students ask a different set of questions: Will this institution protect my mental health? Will I feel safe

here? Will my education have meaning beyond short-term employability?

However, this recalibration also exposes a troubling gap between student expectations and institutional preparedness. While over 80% of students reportedly rely on AI-powered tools for career exploration and university selection, a significantly smaller proportion of counsellors use similar technologies. Even more telling is the finding that family members remain students' most trusted advisers. This reliance reflects both cultural realities and systemic inadequacies. Formal guidance structures in many countries, including India, remain under-resourced, sporadic, and exam-centric.

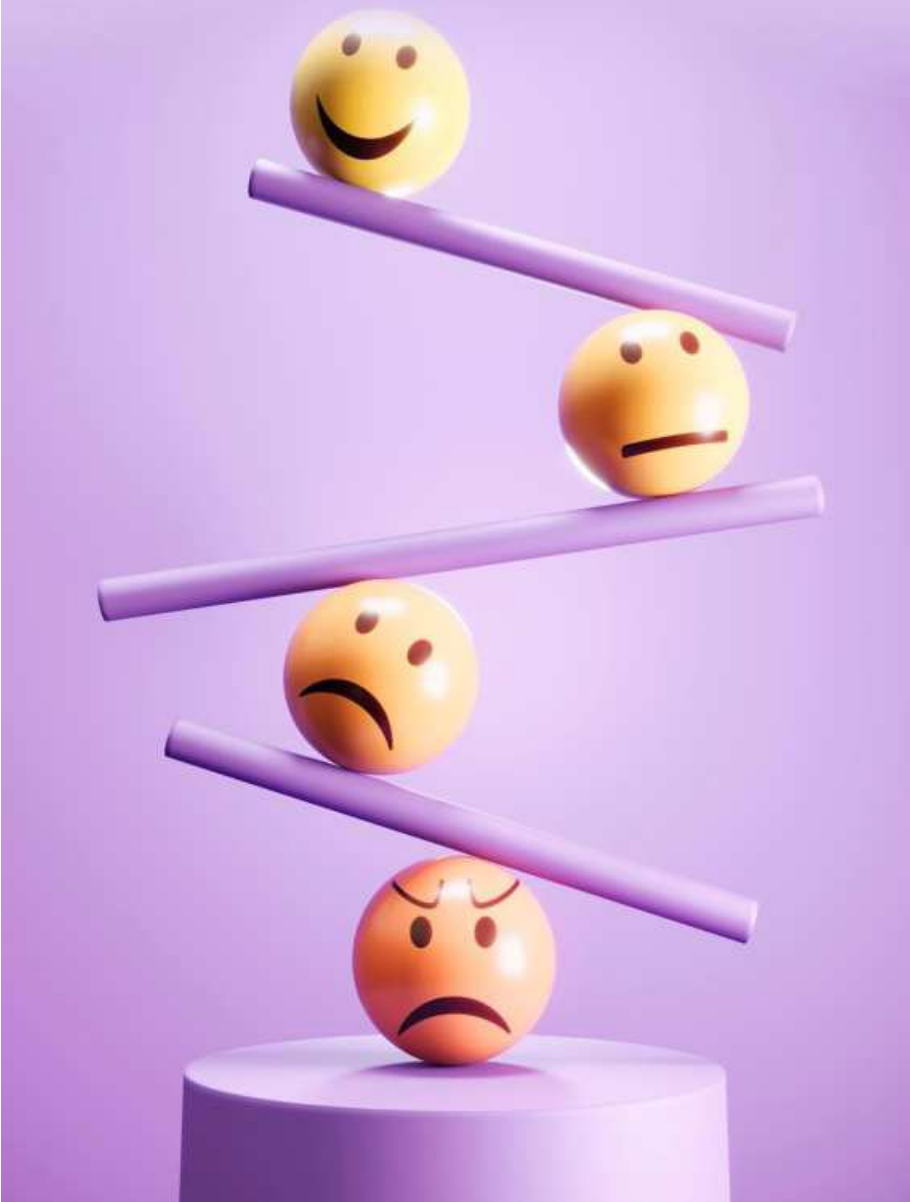
Have students thought this through fully? In part, yes. Their emphasis on well-being and purpose is backed by strong evidence linking mental health to academic success and life outcomes. But there is a danger in over-individualising responsibility. Student preferences alone cannot drive institutional change. The latter requires funding, trained personnel, and a radical shift in academic culture. Without these, well-being risks becoming a slogan rather than a reality.

Indian context

In India, these findings resonate with deep ongoing concerns. Indian campus-

Mind over marks

Why student well-being matters as much as degrees



GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCKPHOTOS

es – both elite and state-run – continue to witness alarming reports of student stress, anxiety, and suicide.

Competitive academic cultures, rigid evaluation systems, caste discrimination, financial pressure, and inadequate psychological support form a combustible mix. Against this backdrop, students' insistence on safety and mental well-being is not a choice but a necessity.

However, the feasibility of implementing this student-centred vision in Indian higher education remains contested, primarily because capacity is uneven. While a handful of private and central institutions have begun investing in counselling centres, mentorship programmes, and flexible curricula, the vast majority struggle with basic staffing, infrastructure, and governance deficits.

Often, inclination is missing. Mental health is still viewed as peripheral, remedial, or individual rather than institutional and preventive.

In this context, the IC3 report's call for "Counselling as a Culture" is significant. It suggests moving beyond token counsellor appointments towards embedding guidance within pedagogy, leadership practices, teacher training, and parental engagement.

In India, this requires a decisive break from the exam-centric mindset that

dominates schooling and higher education. Faculty members will need training not only in subject expertise but also in student mentorship and emotional literacy.

Additionally, government policy plays a critical role. Regulatory bodies such as the UGC must move beyond issuing advisories and insist on enforceable standards for student support systems. Funding mechanisms should recognise counselling services, mental health infrastructure, and faculty development as core academic investments, not optional add-ons.

Equally important is reducing structural syllabi, unrealistic syllabi, compressed academic calendars, punitive assessment practices, and opaque grievance redressal mechanisms.

Institutions, for their part, must confront uncomfortable questions. Do they see students primarily as rank-holders and placement statistics, or as young adults navigating complex personal and social transitions? Are they willing to sacrifice a measure of performative excellence to create humane academic environments? Without such introspection, well-being will remain a policy buzzword rather than an institutional ethic.

The writer is former Professor and Dean, Christ University, Bengaluru.

SCHOLARSHIPS

Rajiv Gandhi University Internship

Provided by the Rajiv Gandhi University, Arunachal Pradesh
Eligibility: Students in a Social Sciences UG/ PG programme
Rewards: Certificate
Application: Online
Deadline: May 15
www.b4s.in/edge/RGAUI

The Cadence/Invecas Scholarship

From Cadence Design Systems and Concern India Foundation
Eligibility: Students from lower-income groups with minimum 80% overall in Class 12 who live and study in Delhi NCR, Bengaluru, Pune, Ahmedabad, and Hyderabad only.
Rewards: Support for key educational expenses.
Application: Online
Deadline: May 10
www.b4s.in/edge/TCSP6

The Einstein Fellowship

From the Einstein Forum and the Wittenstein Foundation.
Eligibility: Individuals with a Humanities, Social Sciences, or Natural Sciences degree and interested in research in a different field.
Rewards: €10,000
Application: Online
Deadline: May 15
www.b4s.in/edge/TEFG1

Courtesy: Buddy4study.com



OFF THE EDGE
Nandini Raman

I finished B.Com. and Taxation in 2025. I am not great at academics, nor do I have any exceptionally good skills. Having a B.Com. degree makes everything worse. I don't know what to do. Name withheld on request.

Your degree is not your destination; it is merely the start line. You have the foundation of accounting, tax, and basic finance. Now, you need to find the one thing that you enjoy doing, that also pays well, and get better at it, one day at a time. Since you did Taxation, consider high-demand roles such as accounts executive, ERP support, or financial analyst. Do online courses in accounting software (three-month certification), SAP FICO, Oracle NetSuite, or QuickBooks.

Work with a Chartered Accountant and learn the job on the go. Tax filing, preparing files, data entry for GST returns, software and advisory support will help you learn the trade, and build your network. Learn how to use ClearTax or Winman software. Learn Microsoft Excel (Advanced), Power BI or Tableau for roles such as business analyst, finance analyst, or MIS executive. Finance teams need people who can take raw numbers and turn them into charts and dashboards that management can understand. Consider doing an MBA or pursuing a professional qualification like

What interests you?

Uncertain about your career options? Low on self-confidence? This column may help



GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCKPHOTO

CA, ACCA, CS, or CMA.

Meet a career counsellor for a personality/career profile to find what your interests are.

I have completed B.Sc. Maths. Should I pursue a PG degree or another course to get a job? Princy

Dear Princy,

The choice between academics and skills depends on what you want, age, current finances, and your appetite for theory versus application. First, the academic path. A two-year M.Sc. in Statistics/Data Science is a natural progression of turning your pure Maths skills into applied and high-paying skills as a data scientist or a statistician.

An MBA Finance or Business Analytics could give you a huge payoff in

investment banking, management consulting, and product management roles. Actuarial Science (risk assessment for insurance/finance) is the gold standard for Maths graduates. A professional qualification, it is extremely difficult, but valuable.

The skills path can make you job-ready in 6-9 months. A certification in Data or business analytics certification with Excel (Advanced), SQL, Power BI or Tableau, and Python is one option. Another is courses on financial modelling, valuation, and Mergers and Acquisitions on platforms such as Imarticus Learning, EduPristine, or the Corporate Finance Institute can lead to jobs such as equity research analyst or financial analyst.

Coding languages with strong Maths applications

such as Python (for backend/AI) or Java will work for jobs in software development and backend engineering.

I have completed a B.Sc. in Botany, but am not landing a job. I am not interested in further studies either. I have enrolled in online civil service coaching, but find it challenging. How can I get a job? Nayana

Dear Nayana,

What do you find challenging about the online coaching? Is it the syllabus, or are you just not interested? The UPSC is not for the faint hearted. If this is what you want, then you have to motivate yourself and persevere. If this is not for you, step away. Do not stay stuck in a loop of confusion and become demotivated.

You have a Science degree but have not matched it to a market need. Before you decide what to do, spend time to figure out what interests you and what you want to do with your life. If you enjoy writing, then the fastest route is the content and communication path. You could be a content writer, science communicator, or subject matter expert for ed-tech companies. You can create question banks, write content for their apps, or explain concepts to students. Update your LinkedIn profile and look for academic writer or curriculum developer roles.

If you enjoy procedures, look for roles such as lab technician, quality control analyst, or quality assurance associate in food processing or pharmaceutical companies or diagnostic labs. A short-term certification in Food Technology, Quality Management, or Good Laboratory Practices will make your CV stronger. But you can also join as a trainee.

Jobs like being an agri-input salesperson (selling seeds/fertilizers), or customer support for a scientific instrument company is also possible, as companies want graduates who can understand the technical side of their business.

I am in Class 10 and am planning a career in Finance. Can I choose Applied Maths in Class 11 and 12? Is it suitable for a finance-related career? Laya

Dear Laya,

Yes, Applied Maths is a smart choice for a finance-related career. The primary focus of Applied Maths is the practical application of mathematical tools to solve real-world

problems in business, Economics, and Social Sciences. It will be a foundation for learning relevant topics such as Basics of Financial Mathematics, Index Numbers and Time-based data.

After Class 12, consider undergraduate programmes such as B.Com Finance, Bachelor of Accounting and Finance (BAF), B.B.A. Finance, Bachelor of Financial Markets (BFM), Bachelor of Business Studies (BBS). This can lead to exciting and rewarding roles such as financial analyst, investment banking, portfolio manager, risk analyst, data scientist and so on.

Disclaimer: This column is merely a guiding voice and provides advice and suggestions on education and careers.

The writer is a practising counsellor and a trainer. Send your questions to eduplus.thehindu@gmail.com with the subject line Off the Edge



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PhD ADMISSIONS 2026

Advt No. RGCB/PhD/2026-II/April 2026 April 16, 2026

BRIC-RGCB invites application for admission to the **Ph.D. program 2026** August session in various domains of Biotechnology from post-graduates having a minimum of 60% marks and 4-year Bachelor's degree having a minimum of 75% marks in Life/ Environmental/ Veterinary/ Pharmaceutical/ Medical Sciences or allied subjects and as per UGC guideline. The candidate should have a valid JRF (UGC/CSIR/ICMR/ DBT or any other nationally-competitive fellowship) offered by the Government of India and should be valid for a period of 5 years. Complete information, application format, eligibility and other details are available on the RGCB website (www.rgcb.res.in). Applications along with prescribed fees must be submitted online through the link given in the web portal on or before **May 10, 2026**. Incomplete applications and applications without processing fees will be rejected.

Sd/-
Director

SAVE THE DATE

SBI Youth for India Fellowship

SBI invites applications for the 14th edition of the SBI Youth for India Fellowship, a 13-month immersive rural development programme designed for youth to work closely with rural

communities across India.
Eligibility: Indian citizens, OCI-card holders or NRIs between 21 and 32 years who hold a Bachelor's degree.
Deadline: April 30
apply.youthforindia.org

Admissions

IIT-Kanpur invites applications to the second cycle of its Online

Postgraduate Programmes: M.Tech Wireless Networks and Machine Learning; RF Engineering; Microelectronics and VLSI; Construction Engineering and Project Management; Sustainable Energy Technologies; AI and Machine Learning, and Smart Grid; M.Sc Economics and Data Analytics, and PG Diploma Cyber Security.

Eligibility: Graduates with minimum CPI 5.5 or 55% in their qualifying degree or scores in valid national examination scores, such as GATE or JAM or IIT Kanpur's own online entrance test.
<https://online.iitk.ac.in/>

JK LakshmiPat University (JKLU), Jaipur, invites applications for its four-year

B.Des with specialisation in Interdisciplinary Design, Product Design, Interaction Design, or Integrated Communication Design.
Eligibility: Minimum 60% aggregate in Class 12, portfolio review and valid score in JKLU Design Entrance Test score or National Design Entrance Exam.
<https://tinyurl.com/4zh86ftr>



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► Footwear Design
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MBA (2 YEARS)
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by the February 12, 2026, order of the Supreme Court to complete the process of appointing a regular DGP within three weeks, the process got delayed on the part of the UPSC due to various reasons. As the situation stands, the top three officers in the order of seniority are Seema Agrawal, Rajeev Kumar, and Sandeep Rai Rathore.

In the next ECM meeting, expected to be held sometime in May, the names of three qualifying officers would be finalised by the UPSC and communicated to the State government. One of them would be appointed as DGP/HoPF with a minimum tenure of two years irrespective of the date of superannuation as per apex court guidelines in the Prakash Singh case.

INBRIEF



Four killed, over 20 injured in serial accidents in Karnataka

Four people, including three of a family, were killed and more than 20 injured in a series of accidents involving multiple vehicles on National Highway no. 50 in Vijayanagara district of Karnataka on Sunday morning. The accidents occurred near Danapur, close to the BMM ISPAT plant, around 8.30 a.m., when a garlic-laden lorry travelling towards Bengaluru reportedly went out of control and rammed several vehicles moving along the busy stretch of the highway.

Modi speaks to Pawan Kalyan, enquires about his well-being

Prime Minister Narendra Modi has enquired about the health of Deputy Chief Minister of Andhra Pradesh, Pawan Kalyan, after he underwent surgery on Saturday. In a post on X, Mr. Modi said, “Spoke to Shri Pawan Kalyan Garu and enquired about his well-being. He is remarkably courageous and I am sure he will recover very soon.” In response, Mr. Pawan Kalyan said he was grateful to Mr. Modi for his kind words and for speaking with him.

Thieves get away with gold from passengers on train

Thieves escaped with 10 sovereigns of gold and other valuables of passengers travelling on a Bengaluru-Narsapur special train in Bapatla district of Andhra Pradesh in the early hours of Sunday. Nearly 10 thieves stole the valuables while the passengers were asleep in the coaches S-11, S-12, and S-13 around 2 a.m. They stopped the train near Appikatla village and escaped. The railway police and the Railway Protection Force alerted the Bapatla law and order police.

Driver swap, brake failure suspected in Valparai crash

Abdul Latheef Naha
PALAKKAD

The Kerala Transport Department is struggling to identify the cause of the accident on the Valparai ghat road near Pollachi on Friday, in which a van from Pang in Malappuram district plunged off the road, claiming nine lives.

Transport officials said the van was so badly damaged that it was difficult to determine whether any mechanical failure had contributed to the accident.

Accident near border
As the accident occurred in Tamil Nadu, the State Transport Department does not have complete autonomy in the investigation.

Meanwhile, it was found that the van was being driven by the school bus driver Noushad at the time of the accident, and not by its regular driver Mohammed Fasith. Both men sustained severe injuries and are currently undergoing treatment.

Transport officials quoting their Tamil Nadu counterparts said it was suspected that the drivers had swapped seats during a short break taken briefly before the vehicle plunged off the 13th hairpin bend. The change of drivers while the vehicle was descending the 36-hairpin ghat road is also believed to have potentially contributed to the fatal accident.

Meanwhile, preliminary probe indicate that brake failure may have caused the accident. It is believed that the braking system could have overheated and failed after the vehicle descended 23 hairpin bends.

Safe harbour



In view of the two-month fishing ban, fishermen on Sunday anchored their motorboats amid the mangrove forests in the Buckingham Canal near Gundamala village in Prakasam district of Andhra Pradesh. KOMMURI SRINIVAS

As AICC issues diktat against ‘discussion on CM candidate’, an uneasy calm prevails in Kerala unit

G. Anand
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

The truce ushered in by the All India Congress Committee (AICC) to tamp down “fractious discussions” about the prospective Congress Legislature Party (CLP) leader and possible Chief Minister candidate if the United Democratic Front (UDF) triumphs in the Assembly election appeared to be holding tenuously in the party in Kerala, for now.

The Kerala Pradesh Congress Committee (KPCC) leadership has attempted, on and off, and with mixed results, to rein in the rank and file from juggling the names of the Congress’s Chief Minister

Revanth meets Governor over clearance of MLC nominations

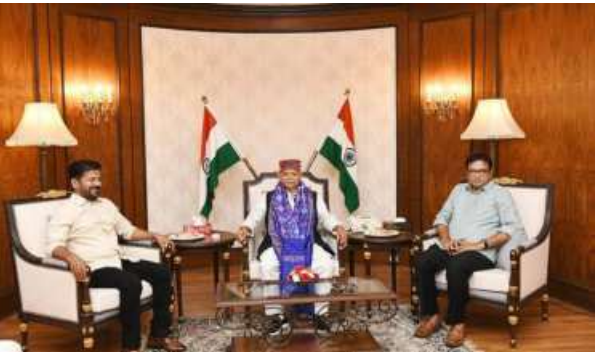
Names of M. Kodandaram and Mohammad Azharuddin, approved by the Cabinet, have been pending with Lok Bhavan; the latter has served as a non-legislator Minister for nearly six months

The Hindu Bureau
HYDERABAD

In a renewed push to break the prolonged deadlock over Telangana Legislative Council nominations, Chief Minister A. Revanth Reddy met Governor Shiv Pratap Shukla at Lok Bhavan on Sunday, urging expeditious approval of pending nominations under the Governor’s quota.

The names of M. Kodandaram and Mohammad Azharuddin, which had been approved earlier by the State Cabinet, remain pending with the Lok Bhavan following the transfer of former Governor Jishnu Dev Varma to Maharashtra.

The Chief Minister accompanied by Industries



Telangana CM Revanth Reddy along with Minister D. Sridhar Babu at a meeting with Governor Shiv Pratap Shukla. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Minister D. Sridhar Babu and Rajya Sabha member Vem Narender Reddy called on Mr. Shukla and sought early clearance of the nominations.

The urgency comes in the wake of Minorities Welfare Minister Mohammad Azharuddin completing his six-month period as Mi-

nister without being a member of the Legislative Assembly or the Council, which is the Constitutional mandatory provision.

He will be completing six months at the end of April, and if he is not nominated as MLC he would have to resign. With the deadline approaching, the

Six drown in the Cauvery in Mysuru; two found dead in tank near Chikkamagaluru

The Hindu Bureau
MYSURU

Eight persons drowned in two separate incidents in Mysuru and Chikkamagaluru districts of Karnataka.

Six persons drowned in the Cauvery river near the Arakeshwara temple in K.R. Nagar taluk on Sunday. According to the police, the six persons were part of a group of eight per-

sons from different places in Mysuru and Bengaluru, who were visiting a nearby dargah for a gathering. While two persons were rescued by the local people and rushed to a nearby hospital, six others, including a couple, two men and two girls drowned in the river.

The K.R. Nagar Police rushed to the spot while personnel from Fire and

Emergency Services fished out the bodies.

In another incident, two persons who went missing on Saturday, were found dead in a tank on Biligiri Estate near Aldur in Chikkamagaluru taluk on Sunday.

The deceased have been identified as Ramesh of Ganapathi Katte village in Koppa taluk, and Mahesh of Kadavathi village in Kop-

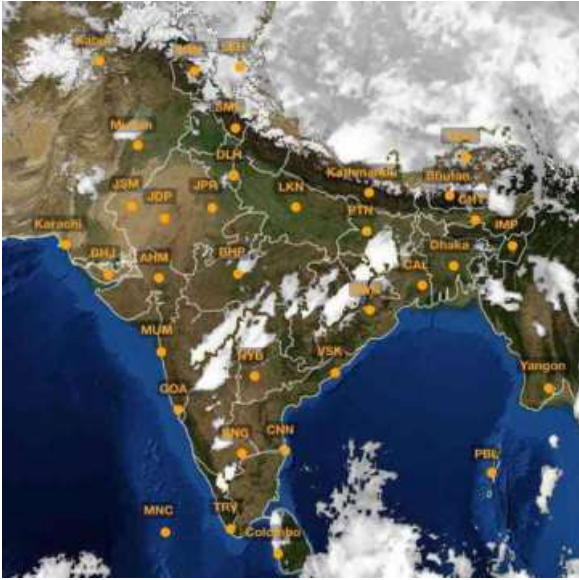
pal taluk. Both had been working at the Biligiri estate for past few months.

They had been there to catch fish in the tank on Saturday evening. As they did not return, neighbours went in search of them and found their footwear near the tank. Later, they informed the police.

The bodies were retrieved from the waterbody on Sunday.

WEATHERWATCH

Rainfall, temperature & air quality in select metros yesterday



TEMPERATURE DATA: IMD, POLLUTION DATA: CPCB, MAP: INSAT/IMD (TAKEN AT 17.00 HRS)

Forecast for Monday: Heavy to Very Heavy Rainfall very likely at isolated places over Arunachal Pradesh. Heat Wave conditions very likely at isolated places over Chhattisgarh, and Uttar Pradesh. Heavy Rainfall very likely at isolated places over Assam and Meghalaya

CITY	RAIN	MAX	MIN	CITY	RAIN	MAX	MIN
Agartala		35.5	26.4	Kozhikode		36.8	28.6
Ahmedabad		40.0	26.9	Kurnool		43.4	29.7
Aizawl	07.0	31.8	19.6	Lucknow		41.9	24.4
Allahabad		44.6	25.0	Madurai		40.0	25.5
Bengaluru		36.2	24.5	Mangaluru		33.7	25.9
Bhopal		41.8	23.6	Mumbai		33.9	24.5
Bhubaneswar		00.0	00.0	Mysuru		37.0	23.0
Chandigarh		39.3	20.8	New Delhi		40.0	22.7
Chennai		34.9	26.6	Patna		39.3	25.6
Coimbatore		39.2	25.8	Port Blair		33.0	25.7
Dehradun		36.7	20.9	Puducherry		34.7	24.2
Gangtok		19.5	15.1	Pune		40.7	22.4
Goa		34.2	26.8	Raipur		44.0	29.9
Guwahati	24.0	28.4	20.6	Ranchi		39.3	23.0
Hubballi		38.0	22.0	Shillong		21.7	14.0
Hyderabad		40.0	24.8	Shimla		30.2	17.5
Imphal		27.2	18.8	Srinagar		21.0	10.5
Jaipur				Thiruvananthapuram		35.0	26.7
Kochi		32.8	28.8	Tiruchi		39.5	26.0
Kohima				Vijayawada			
Kolkata		37.0	26.5	Visakhapatnam		33.0	27.8

Pollutants in the air you are breathing							Yesterday	
CITIES	SO ₂	NO ₂	CO	PM _{2.5}	PM ₁₀	CODE	In observation made at	
Ahmedabad		65	40	17	77	147		4.00 p.m., Ghaziabad and Greater Noida, both in
Bengaluru		11	59	22	70	104		Uttar Pradesh recorded an
Chennai		5	4	36	66	49		overall air quality index
Delhi		22	108	57	311	377		(AQI) score of 336
Hyderabad		2	7	31	72	94		indicating an unhealthy
Kolkata		18	28	13	42	61		level of pollution. In
Lucknow		7	50	75	228	144		contrast, Bhiwani,
Mumbai		3	23	51	83	167		Haryana recorded a
Pune			38	95	73	115		healthy AQI score of 29.
Visakhapatnam		45	50	24	25	92		

Air Quality Code: Poor Moderate Good (Readings indicate average AQI)
SO₂: Sulphur Dioxide. Short-term exposure can harm the respiratory system, making breathing difficult. It can affect visibility by reacting with other air particles to form haze and stain culturally important objects such as statues and monuments.
NO₂: Nitrogen Dioxide. Aggravates respiratory illness, causes haze to form by reacting with other air particles, causes acid rain, pollutes coastal waters.
CO: Carbon monoxide. High concentration in air reduces oxygen supply to critical organs like the heart and brain. At very high levels, it can cause dizziness, confusion, unconsciousness and even death.
PM_{2.5} & PM₁₀: Particulate matter pollution can cause irritation of the eyes, nose and throat, coughing, chest tightness and shortness of breath, reduced lung function, irregular heartbeat, asthma attacks, heart attacks and premature death in people with heart or lung disease

Eight-year-old dies, brother critical after being bitten by snake while sleeping at home

The Hindu Bureau
THRISSUR

An eight-year-old boy died after being bitten by a snake while asleep at his house at Mattathur near Kodakara in Thrissur, Kerala.

The deceased, Aljo, was sleeping alongside his mother and brother when the incident occurred. His elder brother, 10-year-old Aloj, was also bitten and is currently undergoing treatment at a private hospital. His condition is reported to be critical.

According to family members, the children woke up around 2 a.m. on Sunday complaining of dis-

People searched the bedroom and found a snake coiled beneath a pillow on the bed

comfort and stomach pain. As the family had attended a function earlier and had eaten food there, the symptoms were initially suspected to be food-related. The children were given warm water and put back to bed.

However, by around 5.30 a.m., the elder boy again woke his mother, saying he felt unwell. It was then that the younger child was found in a severely

weakened condition. Suspecting food poisoning, the family rushed both children to a nearby private hospital.

Doctors, noticing unusual symptoms, suspected of a snakebite and upon examination identified bite marks on their bodies. Alarmed by this, relatives and neighbours searched the bedroom and found a snake coiled beneath a pillow on the bed. The snake was later killed.

Aljo could not be saved. His brother remains under intensive care. It is suspected that the snake may have entered the house seeking relief from the intense heat outside.

Elderly woman killed in suspected leopard attack in Kerala

The Hindu Bureau
THRISSUR

A 76-year-old woman was killed in a suspected leopard attack at Malakkappara in Kerala on Sunday morning in yet another chilling incident highlighting the growing human-wildlife conflict in the area.

The victim has been identified as Inassi Ammal, a resident near the Sholayar dam area.

Her partially eaten body was found close to her house. She had been reported missing since Saturday evening.

Local people launched a search after she failed to return home and discovered her body in a roadside ditch. Authorities suspect she was attacked by the leopard while stepping out for some work related to her roadside shop.

Malakkappara has long been a hotspot for wildlife attacks.

The incident has sparked fear among residents who say the threat from wild animals has become increasingly severe.

In May last year, a wild elephant trampled a 75-year-old woman to death after attacking her house in Malakkappara. In August, a leopard attacked a four-year-old boy from a tribal settlement. The child suffered severe injuries.



Deceptively benign

India must move from fossil fuel to avoid amplifying imported inflation

While India's March retail inflation, at 3.4%, rose marginally from February's 3.2%, this increase is deceptively benign. This is evident from the upward pressure on the Wholesale Price Index (WPI), which climbed to a 38-month high of 3.88% in March. It is important to note that while the Consumer Price Index (CPI) has transitioned to a new base year of 2024, the WPI continues to use the 2011-12 base year, a divergence that must be kept in mind when interpreting the latest inflation data. While the March CPI appears comfortably within the RBI's 4%-6% tolerance band, the reading masks a far more complex build-up of pressures driven primarily by rising input costs, especially fuel prices. WPI inflation rose from about 2.4% in February to 3.88% in March, indicating a sharp month-on-month acceleration in wholesale price pressures. This has found only muted reflection in food prices, with the Consumer Food Price Index (CFPI) rising moderately from roughly 3.4% in February to about 3.8% in March.

Several factors are driving this divergence, chief among them the rupee's precipitous depreciation of about 2.5%-3% against the U.S. dollar. Given that crude oil and gas are globally traded in dollars, this has amplified imported inflation. The U.S.-Israeli war on Iran has disrupted supply chains for these critical fuels, pushing up global prices and transmitting inflationary pressures across economies. The rupee's depreciation has also raised the cost of imports, including fertilizers, plastics, and petrochemical products, which are key to pharmaceuticals, textiles and automobiles. While many firms have absorbed these costs, this may not be sustainable. At the same time, the contraction in exports (down about 3%-4% year-on-year) and imports (down about 5%-6% YoY) in March is not indicative of weakening demand alone, but of war-induced supply disruptions. In response, exporters – particularly MSMEs – are redirecting output to the domestic market, aided by policy relaxations that allow greater domestic sales from export-oriented units. This is creating localised supply gluts, delaying price pass-through even as producer margins compress due to rising input costs. The result is a temporary suppression of CPI. As these pressures unwind, inflation is likely to rise even as growth slows – pointing not to stability but to emerging stagflationary risks. The IMF's latest World Economic Outlook flags rising global recession risks and trims India's FY27 growth forecast to around 6.2%. The RBI, too, has echoed these concerns. This complex challenge underscores the vulnerability of oil-import-dependent economies. It also presents an opportunity for India to accelerate its shift to renewable energy.

Costs and wages

Governments must not view labour unrest as a law-and-order problem

The ongoing factory workers' protests in Noida's industrial belt are one of the largest industrial labour mobilisations in recent times. Violence has been documented as well: stone-pelting and attempts to breach police barricades, as well as a brutal police lathicharge. After Haryana hiked wages for workers by 35% following protests in Faridabad, Gurugram, and Manesar, workers in Noida realised that their own wages were lower, a situation exacerbated by the pinch in LPG supplies. Trade unions have demanded ₹18,000 to ₹25,000 a month – which the Uttar Pradesh government's interim hike of around 21% did not meet – and fixed working hours and holidays and overtime pay. The new Labour Codes that the Union government enforced from late 2025 allow a 12-hour single work-day and specify wage floors but not actual wages, leaving them to the States. As a result, the Codes have allowed employers in certain States to extract more work from the longer workday at or near the statutory minimum pay. The share of contract labour in the formal manufacturing sector in India is the highest since 1997-98. Ironically, the provisions of the Labour Codes encourage the sector to persist with contract labour rather than appreciate job security, while also imposing limits on worker strikes. These, together with the energy crisis and increasing food prices, precipitated the protests.

In 2024, the Samsung workers' strike in Sriperumbudur, Tamil Nadu, was similarly over low wages, unpaid overtime, and the company's refusal to recognise unions. More recently, workers at the IOCL Panipat refinery went on strike demanding an eight-hour workday, better wages, and safer working conditions, as did workers at the NTPC plant in Patratu, and Adani's Raikheda plant in Raipur. This is practically a wave in the Labour Codes regime, showing that labour rights are paper tigers – exacerbated by Yogi Adityanath's claim that the protests were a conspiracy, followed by the interim hike. A worker who spends one-sixth of his monthly income on cooking costs alone does not need to be radicalised to understand that his wage is insufficient. Further, neither the State nor the Centre responded substantively to residential societies barring domestic workers who had joined the protests by displaying their photographs at the gates – a serious civil rights infraction. The Indian Labour Conference has not convened since 2015, and the Codes were passed without the tripartite consultation that it would have facilitated. The solution to the agitation, in sum, is simple: institute humane working hours and wages, and institute genuine labour reform that is well enforced. The problem only looks complicated because the government is dragging its feet.

A special session of Parliament to consider the Constitution (131st Amendment) Bill, 2026 – and also the Union Territories Laws (Amendment) Bill, 2026, and the Delimitation Bill, 2026 – for readjustment of Lok Sabha and Legislative Assembly seats across the country and implementation of reservation of seats for women in Lok Sabha and Legislative Assemblies (linking it to proposed fresh delimitation for which there was a separate Delimitation Bill) ended in a spectacular way. The proposed delimitation was to reallocate the number of Lok Sabha and State Legislative Assembly seats among States (and Union Territories with legislatures), and determine the territorial boundaries of each constituency, based on data from the 2011 Census. The total number of Lok Sabha seats was proposed to be increased to 850. The special session was convened at a time when electioneering for the ongoing Legislative Assembly elections is at its peak in West Bengal and Tamil Nadu, which did not go down well at all with several Opposition parties.

Law and practice

Articles 82 and 170 (3) of the Constitution require a readjustment of the number of Lok Sabha and Assembly seats in each State and the extent/boundary of every constituency, after each Census. The first delimitation exercise in independent India was carried out in 1950-51 by the Election Commission of India, in consultation with Parliamentary Advisory Committees established for various States. As the delimitation exercise could not await the completion of the 1951 Census, given the urgency of conducting elections at the earliest, the first delimitation was based on estimated population figures, as of March 1, 1950, as provided by the Census Commissioner.

After the completion of the first general election, a fresh delimitation did take place based on the 1951 Census as per the mandate of Articles 82 and 170. Subsequently, readjustment of constituencies, both in terms of number and boundary, was carried out after the Census in 1961 and 1971. The delimitation based on the 1971 Census was completed in 1976. Subsequently, the Forty-Second Amendment of the Constitution of India froze further delimitation until the Census



K.F. Wilfred

Former Senior Principal Secretary of the Election Commission of India

The delimitation debate raises questions on representation and equity

of 2001. The temporary freeze on delimitation was introduced in the context of population control measures actively promoted by the Indira Gandhi government. It was intended to ensure that States successfully curbing population growth were not disadvantaged in terms of representation in Parliament and State Legislative Assemblies due to lower population figures, while States with higher population growth did not gain a corresponding increase in seats.

The issue of population growth

The temporary freeze on delimitation ended in 2001. However, the government led by Atal Bihari Vajpayee at the time decided that it was necessary to continue the freeze on the number of seats in the Lok Sabha and State Legislative Assemblies. The government decided to redraw the territories of constituencies to ensure *inter se* parity in terms of population across them, as this balance had been disrupted/disturbed due to large-scale internal migration of people in search of employment and livelihood since 1971. To this end, the Constitutional provisions were amended in order to provide that territories of the constituencies would be readjusted on the basis of the 2001 Census figures without altering the number of Lok Sabha or Assembly seats.

The Statement of Objects and Reasons in the Bill for the Constitution (Eighty-fourth Amendment) Act, 2001, *inter alia*, stated that, in view of the progress of family planning programmes across different parts of the country, the government – under the National Population Policy strategy – decided to extend the freeze on undertaking fresh delimitation up to the year 2026. This was intended as a motivational measure to enable State governments to continue pursuing the goal of population stabilisation.

Therefore, the apparent thinking at that point of time was that population growth would stabilise across all States within the next 25 years. As per the provisions of Articles 82 and 170(3), as amended in 2001 by the Eighty-Fourth Amendment Act, the freeze on further delimitation is to be in place until the population figures of the first Census to be taken after 2026 are published. In fact, a new national Census (against the delayed 2021 Census) is under way.

The Statement of Objects and Reasons of the current Delimitation Bill, 2026, *inter alia*, noted

Lessons from Hungary's vote and Orbán's defeat

Hungarian voters have swept their far-right strongman Viktor Orbán out of office, ending his 16-year run as Prime Minister and electoral autocrat. Here are six lessons the world can take from them.

First, an illiberal democracy can be ousted in elections. Mr. Orbán prepared the model for what he called 'illiberal democracy' (or electoral autocracy), emulated by many others including Donald Trump and Narendra Modi. Such regimes create an impression of the Great Leader's unstoppable popularity and electoral invincibility – or what we may call the '*aaeyega* to Orbán hi' effect. This produces apathy: voting is either a display of fealty, or an exercise in futility.

Hungarians have shattered that illusion, and India must take note.

Democratic resilience affirmed

Second, obituaries to modern universal democracy are premature. Realist experts, as well as illiberal leaders and ideologues, tell us that democracy has no universal validity, it is elitist and unpopular with the majority, even in the West, as proved by popular mandates for Brexit, Mr. Trump, Mr. Orbán, and Mr. Modi, and the stability of the Chinese and Russian regimes.

Péter Magyar, who defeated Mr. Orbán, is probably as bad on LGBTQIA+ rights as Mr. Orbán and worse on immigration. But the election is not about him. It is about Hungarians affirming, for all of us, that a majority can vote against majoritarianism; that regime change against tyrants is an irrepressible human urge.

Third, a mandate for Ukraine. What is self-evident in Europe might be less so in India; Ukraine won the Hungarian election.

On winning the 2022 elections, Mr. Orbán claimed to have 'overpowered' not only his immediate rivals but also Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy. Going by his party's 2026 campaign billboards, a visitor could be forgiven for assuming that Mr. Orbán's rival was Mr. Zelenskyy, not Mr. Magyar. Mr. Orbán asked Hungarian voters, 'Who should form government: Zelenskyy or me?'



Kavita Krishnan

Feminist activist and writer whose forthcoming book is 'The Global De-Democratisation Project: Script, Actors, Enablers'

Hungarians have defeated a national autocrat and challenged a broader illiberal international alliance

He blamed Hungary's economic crisis on European Union (EU) aid to Ukraine – a pretext for a 'peace plan' that was a wishlist by Russian President Vladimir Putin. It is telling that Hungarian voters rebuffed this notion, despite it being legitimised by some geopolitical and economic pundits.

Instead, Hungarians blamed the wrecked economy on Mr. Orbán's corrupt cronyism that was inseparable from his position as Mr. Putin's Praetor in Europe. He used Russian oil profits to bankroll 'Europe's richest far-right think tank', which funnelled funds to parties such as Reform UK.

United States Vice-President J.D. Vance boasts that cutting off aid to Ukraine is 'one of the proudest' achievements of the Trump administration. To him, as to much of Europe's far-right, a Russian victory over Ukraine would be a victory for what Mr. Vance, in his electoral endorsement of Mr. Orbán, called the 'defence of Western/Christian civilisation and values'.

Like Mr. Trump and Mr. Putin, Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu too endorsed Mr. Orbán because he supports the project of folding Europe into a Russia-led Christian white-supremacist Eurasia, away from the 'evil, globalist' European Union.

Some of the accusations made

Fourth, regime change accusations are confessions. Mr. Vance accused the EU of "one of the worst examples of foreign election interference". Mr. Orbán accused Ukraine of funding the opposition party Tisza, just as he has blamed Pride march protests on 'regime change' and 'colonial' interference by the EU. As is so often the case, the shrillest accusations are often confessions. Not only were Mr. Netanyahu, Mr. Trump and Mr. Vance star campaigners for Mr. Orbán, but he also invited Russian intelligence operatives and experts in online disinformation to run large-scale fake news campaigns. The Russian embassy itself stands accused of running a pro-Orbán influence operation.

Fifth, Mr. Orbán lost power, Chinese President

that the growth of population across different constituencies along with migration from one place to another – especially rural to urban migration – "have resulted in varying density of population in electoral constituencies"; the Bill sought to address this issue. Ironically, for bringing about parity in population among constituencies, both intra-State and inter-States, the population figures of the 2011 Census were to be adopted – this means that the base data to be used for course correction or updating would have been 15-year-old population figures.

Looking ahead

There is nothing to suggest that migration has either stopped or slowed since 2011, or that population growth has stabilised uniformly across all regions. Against this backdrop, there is no assurance/guarantee that constituencies based on the 2011 Census would stand the test of parity or uniformity in terms of population – and, by extension, in the electorate – at the point when the delimitation exercise would have been completed.

It was quite likely that when constituencies are finally carved out a couple of years down the line, many of them would exhibit clear and evident real-time disparities when compared with the principles set out in the Statement of Objects and Reasons of the present Bill.

Article 81(2) of the Constitution provides that each State shall be allotted Lok Sabha seats in such a manner that the ratio of seats to population, as far as practicable, remains the same across all States.

There is no dispute that the letter of this Article only refers to population as a criterion. However, if we take a broader view, there would be inherent provisions in the Constitution to support the States to retain their scale of parliamentary representation. There may also be scope to incorporate additional parameters/markers alongside population, especially since the number of seats is expected to increase significantly this time, unlike the relatively modest/nominal increases in earlier exercises. After all, States are the component units forming the Union. Strong components will only strengthen the Union.

The views expressed are personal

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Rejection of Bill

The address by the Prime Minister to the nation (Front page, "NDA will remove hurdles before women's quota: PM", April 19) was uncalled for and does not befit his stature. His rant against the Opposition on national television betrays the government's inability to take defeat in its stride. The government is following a 'my way or the highway' approach by threatening Opposition parties with consequences merely because they rightfully rejected the Constitution (131st Amendment) Bill. If the passage of the women's

reservation Bill is indeed the leitmotif of the government of the day, it should not shy away from delinking it from the delimitation Bill. The electorate cannot be taken for a ride any longer, and the government should stop crying foul. **Aanya Singhal**, Noida, Uttar Pradesh

The failure of the Constitution (131st Amendment) Bill, 2026 reflects the will of the electorate as expressed through their representatives. Unlike in the past, the Opposition's

united stand in defeating a rather unjustified Bill offers a lesson to the ruling regime, which has grown accustomed to taking other parties for granted. The Home Minister's accusation that the Opposition is engaging in "ruthless politics" would be better directed at the ruling BJP, which attempted to pass the Bill without proper discussion in the House. The Prime Minister's description of the Bill's defeat as an "attack on women's dignity", along with his assertion that the Opposition will receive a befitting response, sounds

more like election rhetoric. It raises the question of why the Women's Reservation Bill is being linked to the Delimitation Bill. **Prabhu Raj R.**, Bengaluru

Honeybee farming

I am with the Laboratory of Palynology and Paleocology at the French Institute of Pondicherry and read with interest the report, "Keeping honeybees warm in Kashmir winters" (April 19). *Apis cerana*/*Apis cerana indica*, *Apis florea*, *Apis dorsata*, *Apis indica*, *Apis karingjodian*, and *Apis laboriosa* are among the

currently accepted species of honeybees native to Asia and are certainly found in South Asia. Of course, the report focuses on *Apis mellifera*, a species introduced across the world by European and settler colonists (from Australia and New Zealand to South, Central, and North America). The report is of interest from the perspective of an apple farmer in Kashmir who must physically migrate bee boxes to the plains to survive the harsh winter. However, it misses key ecological points and some nuances that are

increasingly being recognised regarding the role of non-human actors in our human-centred world, often referred to as the Anthropocene. Diversity matters for all ecosystems, and monofloral honeys undermine this principle. Flowering ceases during frost, and even apple trees do not bloom in winter. A report such as this, with links to the CSIR study or report for further details, would be most helpful. **Anupama Krishnamurthy**, Pudukcherry

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address.

Differentiating welfare and development

In contemporary democratic politics, development has emerged as a central electoral promise, often framed as a politically resonant goal that transcends ideological divides. Political actors deploy the language of development to signal commitments to economic growth, infrastructure expansion, employment generation, and improved public services, thereby appealing to a broad spectrum of voters. In India, development-oriented campaigns have increasingly emphasised visible and tangible outcomes such as infrastructure, roads, housing etc. However, the political assurance of development can obscure distributional concerns, mask inequalities, or reduce complex socio-economic challenges to simplified slogans. Political parties’ claims of delivering development are ridden with confusion between welfare and development and the pace with which development manifests.

Complementary but different
The confusion between welfare and development arises from their frequent overlap in political and policy discourse. Welfare typically refers to immediate, redistributive interventions aimed at alleviating poverty, reducing vulnerability, and ensuring basic needs such as food security, income support, and access to essential services. Development, in contrast, denotes a broader, long-term process of structural transformation involving sustained economic growth, productivity enhancement, and expansion of human capabilities. However, in practice, the boundaries between the two often blur. This conflation is evident in the Indian context, where large-scale social protection programmes coexist with ambitions of rapid economic growth. The persistence of confusion lies in the differing time horizons and objectives: welfare is often short-term and consumption-oriented, while development is long-term and



M. Suresh Babu
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Conflating populist welfare promises and long-term development goals poses significant risks as it prioritises short-term political gains over long-term economic capacity

production-oriented. A more coherent approach requires recognising welfare and development as complementary rather than interchangeable. Tensions persist between welfare provisioning and development objectives, particularly in the context of fiscal constraints and concerns about efficiency. Excessive redistribution may distort incentives and crowd out productive investment. The design and quality of welfare programmes are critical determinants of their developmental impact, as poorly designed interventions may lead to leakages, exclusion errors, and limited effectiveness. Political claims of delivering development often refer to short-term visible outcomes. Development is best understood as an incremental and long-term process rather than a series of discrete, short-term achievements. It involves the gradual transformation of economic structures, institutional capacities, and social outcomes over extended periods, often spanning decades. Unlike episodic policy successes or visible infrastructure projects, development unfolds through cumulative improvements in productivity, human capital, technological adoption, and governance systems. Scholars have emphasised the role of institutions in shaping this evolutionary trajectory, highlighting that sustainable development depends on the slow consolidation of rules, norms, and state capacity. Similarly, the capability approach associated with Amartya Sen underscores that expanding human freedoms – through education, health, and social inclusion – is a gradual process requiring sustained public investment and policy continuity. This perspective cautions against viewing development through the lens of immediate outcomes or electoral cycles, and instead frames it as a continuous, path-dependent process where incremental gains, if consistently

reinforced, lead to substantive and durable transformations. The notion of “quick development” as promised by political parties reflects a persistent fallacy in policy and political discourse, rooted in the expectation that complex transformations can be achieved within short time frames. **Dangers of welfare populism**
Public goods such as quality schooling, public health systems, infrastructure, and rule of law are generally more conducive to long-term development than welfare populism. They raise productivity and generate broad, economy-wide benefits over time. Because they are non-excludable and produce strong positive externalities, their impact tends to be durable, cumulative, and inclusive. In contrast, populist ‘development welfarism’ such as politically motivated transfers which include free electricity, loan waivers, or cash handouts prioritise immediate consumption gains and electoral appeal. While these measures can provide short-term relief, they often do not expand productive capacity. Importantly when overused, they can strain public finances and crowd out investment in public goods. However, well-designed welfare schemes such as nutrition support, employment guarantees, or basic income floors can enhance human capabilities, reduce vulnerability, and even improve productivity. The problem is not welfare per se, but populist and fiscally unsustainable welfare that substitutes for, rather than complements, development. Conflating populist welfare promises and long-term development goals poses significant risks as it prioritises short-term political gains over long-term economic capacity. The challenge for policymakers lies in designing welfare systems that are fiscally sustainable, institutionally robust, and aligned with long-term objectives. It is time that election manifestos acknowledge this and embark on refinements.

Power play among the young and old

There have been signs of discord among the BJP’s top leadership in Rajasthan

STATE OF PLAY

Mohammed Iqbal
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The recent utterances of the former Chief Minister of Rajasthan, Vasundhara Raje, have brought her to the centre of a political storm, and has hinted at signals of dissent within the ruling Bharatiya Janata Party’s (BJP) internal circle in Rajasthan. Ms. Raje, who does not exercise power at present, had been asking to give responsibilities to loyal party workers. Widely recognised for her grassroots leadership, Ms. Raje had launched a ‘Jansamvad Yatra’ along with her son, the MP of Jhalawar-Baran, Dushyant Singh, as a public outreach event. Addressing a gathering at Manohar Thana, the former CM thanked the public for their support and affection and highlighted her long association with the region. Calling upon the people to maintain their love and trust, Ms. Raje said that some small issues would always keep coming up, “someone’s house is not getting built, someone’s pension is not being released, someone has not received [adequate] compensation. Someone else got it, I didn’t, that also happens. This is the world, it goes on. But, together, we will try to resolve these issues,” she said. Ms. Raje further added, “...it happens with me too. I could not do anything even for myself. I lost mine. I could not save myself”. These remarks went viral on social media platforms and created a political storm, with critics claiming that a disgruntled Ms. Raje was conveying her pain over not getting the Chief Minister’s post when the BJP was elected



to power in 2023. Ms. Raje was considered a frontrunner for the Chief Minister’s post (it would have been her third term) after the BJP returned to power in the State. However, the party appointed first-time MLA Bhajan Lal Sharma as the new CM, forcing Ms. Raje to announce his name at a BJP legislature party meeting. She has since been seen as being sidelined in important party matters. On the face of it, Ms. Raje’s remarks seemed to have reflected her dissatisfaction over her “weak position” in the BJP at the age of 73. Her supporters have often pointed out that she only holds the position of the party’s national vice-president, while her contemporaries – former Gujarat CM Narendra Modi and former Madhya Pradesh CM Shivraj Singh Chouhan – are relishing power at the Centre. **Opposition jabs**
Samajwadi Party chief Akhilesh Yadav, who was on a brief visit to Jaipur when the controversy emerged, added an element of political intrigue with his statements made to journalists. When asked about the BJP government’s performance in the State, Mr. Yadav said, “Let me speak my mind. If Vasundhara Ji were the Chief Minister, better work would have been done [in Rajasthan].” Targeting the BJP’s much-publicised “double-engine government” model, Mr.

Yadav remarked that instead of working in tandem, the two engines appeared to be “colliding rather than accelerating”. He mocked the internal discord in the BJP and said that there was a lack of authority in the ruling set-up because of the manner in which the Chief Minister was appointed. Not one to miss an opportunity, veteran Congress leader and former CM Ashok Gehlot joined in and agreed with Mr. Yadav’s remarks. “There is weight in what Mr. Yadav has stated. Ever since a *parchi* (slip) regime has been formed in Rajasthan, there is no serious governance. The government focuses only on media appearances,” Mr. Gehlot said. As the matter escalated with BJP State president Madan Rathore and other senior leaders offering explanations, Ms. Raje was compelled to set the record straight. She made it clear that her remarks were not about the CM’s post, but about “road alignment and house demolition” issues. Ms. Raje said she was trying to tell the people that a highway passed in front of her house in Dholpur, and that she had to move her boundary wall back. “When some people approached me to get a highway alignment changed because it would pass through their land, I told them I could not help them as I could not stop it for my own house,” she said. While the former CM affirmed that her statement was twisted and taken out of context, there is an impression about a rift emerging in the BJP amid attempts to establish a new generation of leadership coming out of Ms. Raje’s political shadow. Evidently, the party needs to evolve a balance between the ambitions of young leaders and respect for the elderly and seasoned politicians.

Why Noida’s factory unrest is about more than just wages

Even after the post-protest revision of wages, workers argue that the increase is nominal and that they are constrained by high cost-of-living

DATA POINT

Devvyanshi Bihani

The streets of Noida’s industrial belt saw scenes of unrest on April 13 as protesting factory workers set vehicles ablaze, hurled stones, and clashed with the police. Workers from multiple units gathered in large numbers, accusing employers of low wages, irregular payments, and exploitative practices. The protests point to a structural issue in India’s labour market, where industries may be formally registered, but workers within them often lack basic protections such as written contracts and social security. Data shows that even among regular wage and salaried workers in non-agricultural sectors, informality remains widespread. In 2025, about 58.2% of workers had no written job contract, while 51.7% were not eligible for any social security benefits. In addition, 47.3% were not eligible for paid leave. This means that a significant section of workers employed in formal establishments are, in practice, informally employed. The extent of this informalisation varies across States (**Chart 1**). Uttar Pradesh, where the Gautam Buddha Nagar (Noida) protests took place, stands out on multiple indicators. Around 67.8% of regular workers in the State had no written contract, 62.4% were not eligible for paid leave, and 59.2% lacked access to any specified social security benefit. Further, 46.3% of workers in the State were simultaneously without a written contract, paid leave, and social security – among the highest proportions across States. Bihar, Chhattisgarh and Rajasthan also report high levels of deprivation across these indicators. One factor underlying this trend is the growing reliance on contract labour. Data indicates that the share of contract workers in total industrial employment has

risen steadily over the past decade, from about 35% in 2014-15 to 42% in 2023-24 (**Chart 2**). This suggests a structural shift in employment practices, with firms increasingly relying on intermediaries to hire workers. Workers hired through contractors are less likely to have written agreements, paid leave, or access to social security schemes such as Employees’ State Insurance (ESI). This helps explain the contradiction at the centre of the Noida protests: workers employed within formal factories demanding basic protections typically associated with formal employment. The Centre of Indian Trade Unions (CITU) president, Sudip Dutta, pointed to broader concerns around workplace conditions, including long hours in difficult environments, lack of basic facilities, and how contract workers are vulnerable to arbitrary dismissals. He argued that the increasing reliance on contract labour has weakened the enforcement of labour protections on the ground. While the increase in minimum wages (**Chart 3**) appears significant, it is because the base wage itself is very low. For instance, in Delhi, monthly wages for unskilled workers rose from ₹9,568 in April 2016 to ₹18,456 in April 2025 which is an increase of about 92.9%. In Haryana, wages were increased only by about 39% between 2016 and 2025. However, following the recent labour unrest reported from Manesar, Faridabad, and Gurugram, the State announced a revision of around 35% over the previous year, taking the overall increase since 2016 to about 88.6%. In Uttar Pradesh, the minimum wage for unskilled workers rose from ₹7,107 in April 2016 to ₹11,313 in April 2026. The wage revision announced by Haryana on April 9, triggered protests in Noida, prompting the Uttar Pradesh government to announce an interim solution late that night. The State announced an interim increase of up to 21% for unskilled workers in

industrial areas such as Noida and Ghaziabad, raising wages from ₹11,313 to ₹13,690 per month. It is also important to note that minimum wages in Uttar Pradesh vary by location. Workers in industrial districts such as Gautam Buddha Nagar and Ghaziabad receive higher wages than those in municipal areas and other districts. However, nominal wage increases tell only part of the story. Consumer prices for industrial workers, a key measure of inflation, have also risen significantly over the same period (**Chart 4**). Based on CPI-IW data from the Labour Bureau, price increases across key Delhi-NCR industrial centres range from about 43.7% to 52.7% since 2016. In Delhi, the increase stands at about 43.7%, while in Gurugram and Ghaziabad, it exceeds 50%. Across Uttar Pradesh’s industrial centres including Kanpur, Lucknow, Varanasi and Agra, the increase ranges from about 49.8% to 50.6%. Even after the post-protest revision, workers argue that the increase in wage is nominal and that they are constrained by costs of living. The pressure has intensified in recent months, as several industrial units have been affected by rising input costs. First due to U.S. tariffs and more recently due to disruptions linked to the Strait of Hormuz. But trade unions argue that the burden is being disproportionately passed on to labour. “Whatever be the pressure over the industries... it cannot be transferred to the workers,” the CITU leader said. For workers, many of whom are migrants, the impact is immediate and visible in everyday expenses. “Which worker has an LPG connection?..They rely on the retail market,” he said, adding that the cost of cooking fuel has risen around ₹3,000-₹4,000 in the last month. Data suggests that the issue is not merely about wages, but about the nature of employment itself. (Inputs from Mayank Kumar and Ashok Kumar)

Reading into contracts

The data were sourced from the Periodic Labour Force Survey (PLFS), the Annual Survey of Industries (ASI), the Labour Department and the Labour Bureau

CHART 1: Top 10 States with highest share of workers lacking paid leave, written contracts, and social security benefits (in %)

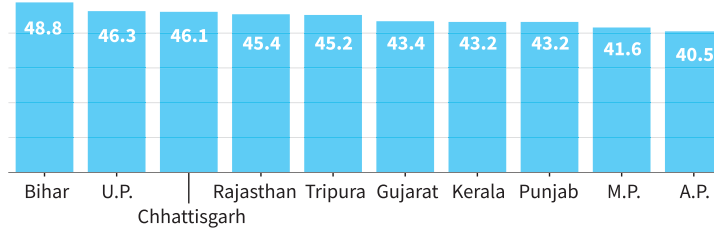


CHART 2: The share of contract workers in total industrial employment (in %)

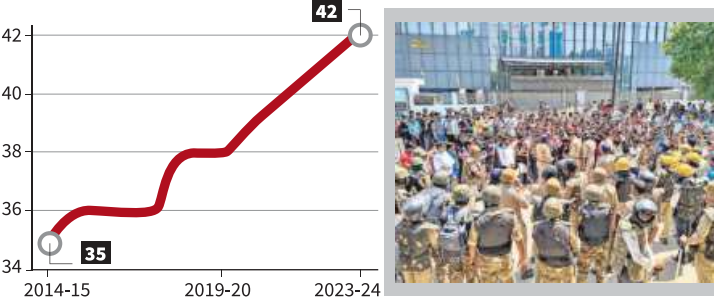


CHART 3: The change in minimum wages for unskilled workers across Delhi, Haryana, and Uttar Pradesh

State	Past minimum wage for unskilled workers (in ₹)	Revised minimum wage for unskilled workers (in ₹)	Estimated wage increase (in %)	Note: Past minimum wage figures correspond to April 1, 2016 (Delhi); July 1, 2016 (Haryana); and April 1, 2016 (Uttar Pradesh). Revised minimum wage figures correspond to April 1, 2025 (Delhi); April 9, 2026 (Haryana); and April 14, 2026 (Uttar Pradesh)
Delhi	9,568	18,456	92.9	
Haryana	8,070.44	15,220.71	88.6	
Uttar Pradesh	7,107.64	12,356-13,690 (Varies by district/municipal corporation)	73.8% - 92.6%	

CHART 4: The industrial centre-wise increase in consumer price index for industrial workers (CPI-IW)

State	Industrial centre	Increase (in %)
Delhi	Delhi	43.7%
Haryana	Yamunanagar	52.6%
Haryana	Faridabad	48.1%
Haryana	Gurugram	52.7%
Uttar Pradesh	Ghaziabad/Noida	51.3%
Uttar Pradesh	Agra	51.5%
Uttar Pradesh	Kanpur	49.8%
Uttar Pradesh	Varanasi	50.6%
Uttar Pradesh	Lucknow	50.7%

FROM THE ARCHIVES

The **Hindu.**

FIFTY YEARS AGO APRIL 20, 1976

Meteors used for radio link

New Delhi, April 19: Scientists have sent signals from Dehru Dun to Waltair, a distance of 1,760 km by bouncing radio waves of meteors. The meteors used for radio communication were midway between the two towns and about 100 km above the ground. Radio waves at 48.2 megacycles were aimed at the meteors from the Himalayas Radio Propagation Unit (HRPU) at Dehru Dun. The echoes were picked up by an oversized television antenna at the Space Research Laboratory in the Physics Department of Andhra University in Waltair. Signals from a low power transmitter could be transmitted this way from Dehra Dun to Waltair. It has been known for a long time that trails left behind by passing meteors are capable of scattering radio waves of frequencies higher than those used for normal ionospheric transmission. In India, the use of meteors in Very High Frequency (VHF) communications is under study by Dr. E. Bhagirat Rao of HRPU, and by Dr. B. Ramachandra Rao, Dr. M. Srirama Rao, Dr. S. Raja Ratnam and by Dr. D.A.V. Krishna Rao of Andhra University. They have reported their preliminary findings about radio meteors in the latest issue of the Indian Journal of Radio and Space Physics. Meteors criss-cross the sky throughout the year. But their activity is highest during meteoric “showers” that occur on predictable dates 80 or 40 times a year.

A HUNDRED YEARS AGO APRIL 20, 1926

Mill strike in Bengal

Calcutta, April 19: A serious situation has arisen out of the strikes of weavers of the India Jute Mills, Serampore on Thursday last. Following the example of these men, the workers of the Angus Anglo-India Alliance and Alexandra Mills in the districts of Hooghly and the Twenty-four Parganas have gone on strike on the question of wages and working hours, thus rendering about 30,000 men idle. It is reported that the Head-Clerk of the Angus Jute Mills at Bhagdeswar was seriously assaulted by the strikers as he was suspected to have had much to do with the reduction of wages, and that the Mill building was damaged to a certain extent. The strike at Gouripore Mill at Naibati has come to an end.

CM
YK

ASSEMBLY POLLS

EC takes action against 11,000 ‘unlawful’ posts

▼ The Election Commission (EC) on Sunday said it had taken action against 11,000 “unlawful” social media posts and other content related to the election to five Assemblies. The EC pointed to its direction that any misleading or unlawful AI-generated or manipulated content had to be acted upon

within three hours of being brought to the notice of the social media platforms. Political parties and candidates have to ensure that synthetically generated or AI-altered content used for campaigning is labelled as “AI-generated”, “digitally enhanced” or “synthetic content”, along with disclosure of the originating entity. Since the elections were announced on March 15, over 11,000 such social media posts/URLs have been identified and acted upon. PTI



Social media platforms have to take action against these posts within three hours. GETTY IMAGES

A.P. CM to go on campaign tour in Tamil Nadu

▼ Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister N. Chandrababu Naidu will embark on a two-day campaign tour in Tamil Nadu beginning on Monday, as part of the National Democratic Alliance (NDA)’s intensified outreach in the State. The visit is aimed at energising party cadre, strengthening voter

engagement, and reinforcing its development-oriented narrative. The Chief Minister will commence his tour in Coimbatore, where he is scheduled to address a public meeting. He will then travel to Hosur and proceed to Thalli to participate in a public rally. Later, Mr. Naidu will arrive in Chennai and take part in a major roadshow in Avadi. On the second day, the Chief Minister will visit Madurai before heading to Sattur.



Corruption allegations have become a pattern in the DMK government. It is time to raise your voice and bid farewell to the ruling dispensation
RAJNATH SINGH
Union Defence Minister

Body of missing Assam polling official retrieved

▼ The police in central Assam’s Karbi Anglong district have recovered the body of a polling official, who went missing during polling hours on April 9. A district official said on Sunday that the body of Cornelius Kindu was recovered from the remote Rongwongwey area. The body has been sent for autopsy.



A new dawn will come, a government that will look after aspirations of mothers, sisters, youth, elderly and farmers will be installed in Bengal
NTIN NABIN
BJP president



I-PAC co-founder Vinesh Chandel being produced at a judge’s residence in New Delhi on April 14 after his arrest by the ED in the Bengal coal scam case. ANI

I-PAC under pressure to leave Bengal, says Mamata

Shiv Sahay Singh
KOLKATA

With just four days to go for polling in the first phase of the West Bengal Assembly election, the political discourse in the State was abuzz on Sunday over speculation that the political consultancy firm I-PAC, which manages the Trinamool Congress’s campaign, has suspended operations in the State. While the Trinamool leadership quickly dismissed the speculation, there were reports by certain media outlets claiming that the I-PAC team in West Bengal had been asked to go on leave for 20 days. There was no response from I-PAC over the reports of its suspension of operations. “We have come across a media report claiming that I-PAC has “halted its operations in West Bengal for the next 20 days”. This claim is completely baseless and appears to be a deliberate attempt to create confusion on the ground, the Trinamool Congress posted on social media. The State’s ruling party further said the I-PAC team in the State remained fully engaged with the party, and campaign operations continued as planned. “These narratives are a deliberate attempt to distract from the clear mood on the ground. The people of Bengal are fully capable of seeing through these attempts and will respond democratically,” the statement said. It added that the State would not be swayed by misinformation or intimidation and would respond decisively. Later in the day, Trinamool Congress chairperson and Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee said that the agency was being pressured to leave West Bengal. She said that she would hire everyone in the firm and absorb them in the party. She said that she had a word with party general secretary Abhishek Banerjee over the developments. “You are asking these agencies, who work for our party, to leave Bengal. Why? You have 50 agencies; we have only one. Listen, if you try to intimidate them, they will join my party. We will give them jobs. We will take care of them. Remember this, I will not let a single person lose their job,” Ms. Banerjee said at a public meeting. I-PAC has been the backbone of the planning and election strategy for the Trinamool for the past several elections. In 2021, the political consultancy firm under the leadership of Prashant Kishor successfully resisted the onslaught of the BJP. The party then engaged I-PAC in the 2024 Lok Sabha polls, in which the Trinamool increased its seats to 29 from 22 in 2019. If I-PAC suspends its operations at this crucial juncture, the Trinamool will face a serious challenge against the well-oiled election machinery of the BJP. Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Union Home Minister Amit Shah are holding multiple rallies along with Chief Ministers of several BJP-ruled States. On January 8, 2026, the Enforcement Directorate conducted searches at the office and residence of I-PAC co-founder Pratik Jain in connection with a coal smuggling scam. The Chief Minister intervened during the search and allegedly took documents from the possession of the ED officials. The ED has approached the Supreme Court against Ms. Banerjee, and the case is pending. On April 13, the ED arrested Vinesh Chandel, a director and co-founder of I-PAC, in a money-laundering case linked to an alleged coal scam in the State. Searches were held in several States and cities in connection with the coal smuggling scam.

Mining-hit Raniganj region takes poll promises with a pinch of salt

Land subsidence, relocation concerns, and livelihood fears dominate electoral discourse in Raniganj coal belt; in Harishpur and Jamuria, families who lost their homes because of land subsidence are being rehabilitated in single-room flats; people are demanding compensation for land instead

GROUND REPORT

Shrabana Chatterjee
PASCHIM BARDHAMAN

As elections approach, promises of rehabilitation take centre stage in India’s second largest and oldest coal mining region in Raniganj in Paschim Bardhaman district of West Bengal. But cracks in homes, unstable ground underneath, and failed rehabilitation promises have haunted residents of the area through many elections. Harishpur is among the worst-affected areas due to land subsidence in Raniganj. In 2020, residents suffered a massive jolt which cracked open many homes, reduced some to dust, and left several families homeless. “We will not accept this rehabilitation. They must compensate us for our land and homes. We will build our own homes at a safer place. We do not want to live in those pigeonholes. No village dweller can think of living on the fourth floor without their land and cattle,” Santosh Chowdhury, a resident of Harishpur, said. Around 150 families spent many sleepless

nights in staff quarters of Eastern Coalfields Ltd., with three families packed into a single flat. Slowly, residents of Harishpur began risking their lives by returning to their dilapidated homes. For the past six years, they have lived in a constant state of fear of losing everything overnight. Many houses are now deserted as residents have left with no hope of proper rehabilitation in sight. Mr. Chowdhury, a teacher at the local Harishpur Free Primary School, said he fears that if they move to the rehabilitation centre near the Andal airport, at least 10 km away, neither his school nor the villagers’ livelihoods will survive. Local people said they were not consulted before the rehabilitation plans were drawn up. They said the Asansol Durgapur Development Authority and the Union and State governments keep passing the responsibility to each other, leaving residents to suffer. Three weeks ago, at a public rally, Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee asked residents of vulnerable locations to move to the rehabilitation centres built by the government. “Life is most important. Not one, but we will give you two flats each. We will



Unfulfilled demands: Hundreds of rehabilitation buildings and flats remain empty as local people refuse to take them without an assurance of livelihood. SHRABANA CHATTERJEE

also give you money to shift. Total ₹10 lakh each for a family, we have estimated,” Ms. Banerjee said. She said that if a sudden landslide took place in coal mining areas, thousands of lives could be lost. However, Kalobaran Mondal, the Trinamool candidate for the Assembly election from Raniganj, said that people were reluctant to shift because the houses were very small. “They are asking for land where they can make their own houses. They

fear that they will not find employment in the new area,” Mr. Mondal added. Naran Bauri of the CPI (M), a candidate from Raniganj, said that coal mines so close to human habitation should not be allowed. “How will the people find work if they are shifted so far away from their hometown,” Mr. Bauri asked. **Failed rehabilitation** Rehabilitation is not a new issue in the Raniganj coal belt. Adjacent to Harishpur are the coal mines of the Ja-

muria constituency, part of the Raniganj coal belt, where about 160 families were shifted from their rural homes in Sripur to flats at least 15 km away in the industrial area of Hingelgora. Their homes crumbled in 2011 after land subsidence. They lived in camps for over 11 years before being moved to the new flats in 2022. Families received ₹10,000 as shifting costs and the equivalent of 500 days of daily wages, but no compensation for the land.

“Once they put us here, they forgot about us. No politicians or authorities come here any more,” Raghubir Prasad, a local activist, said. With no land or cattle, members of the community are now forced to work in nearby industries. Thousands of flats remain vacant as villagers refuse to accept rehabilitation. “At least five people here have died of lung cancer in the past three years. This area is so polluted due to the factories,” Mr. Prasad said. These 160 families were also promised two flats each. But when they arrived, they received only one flat each, forcing families of four to six members to live in a single-room flat. “There is no holistic approach to rehabilitation. The families are stuffed into these caged flats like cattle. They have to survive the high pollution levels even though they are not related to it,” Sudipta Pal, a human rights activist and joint secretary of the ECL (Asansol-Durgapur) Workers Union, said. She added that the government is constructing rehabilitation projects across Raniganj to ease immediate concerns, but lacks a long-term approach to help the displaced people.

Trinamool conspired with Cong. to betray women, says Modi in Bengal

Shiv Sahay Singh
KOLKATA

Addressing election meetings in West Bengal, Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Sunday accused the ruling Trinamool Congress of conspiring with the Congress and “betraying” women by preventing the passage of the Constitution (131st Amendment) Bill, 2026 in Parliament. He said the women of the State should punish the Trinamool in the upcoming Assembly polls. “Trinamool has betrayed the women of Bengal one more time. The sisters of Bengal wanted 33% reservation. Modi tried to ensure that. But Trinamool did not want more number of women from Bengal to become MPs and MLAs because they will challenge the mahajungle raaj of the Trinamool,” Mr. Modi said at a public meeting at Bishnupur in Bankura. Claiming that the Trinamool and the Congress did not allow the women’s reservation Bill to pass, he said, “When you vote, you will have to punish Trinamool for this crime.” His remarks came two days after the BJP-led government failed to secure passage of the Constitution (131st Amendment) Bill in the Lok Sabha. The Bill



Narendra Modi having jhalmuri, a puffed rice snack, during a break from public meetings in West Bengal on Sunday. ANI

sought to redistribute Lok Sabha seats on the basis of the 2011 Census to expedite the implementation of women’s reservation. Mr. Modi addressed four public meetings in Bankura, Purulia, Jhargram, and Paschim Medinipur in the tribal-dominated south West Bengal, where polling will be held on April 23. In his address, Mr. Modi described the Trinamool as ‘anti-tribal’, stating that the party had fielded a candidate against President Droupadi Murmu in the Presidential election. “The whole world respects Droupadi Murmu but the Trinamool which is anti-tribal had insulted her,” Mr. Modi said referring to an incident last month in Darjeeling district where proper protocol was not accorded to the President.

Highlighting the schemes of the Union government, Mr. Modi said in the past 15 years, the Trinamool had ignored tribals. “No education, no employment and no irrigation,” he said. Pointing out that there are particularly vulnerable tribal groups such as Toto, Lodha, and Sabar for whom benefits are being given under the PM JANMAN Yojana, Mr. Modi alleged that the State government had not implemented the scheme. The Prime Minister accused the Mamata Banerjee government of pursuing politics that favoured “infiltrators” and said that the upcoming Assembly election “was a battle to save the State’s identity”. “The path that the Trinamool is treading is very dangerous. The Trinamool

wants to form a government of infiltrators and for infiltrators. A government that will protect only the religion, language, and customs of the infiltrators, rather than those of the people of Bengal,” he said. Mr. Modi came down heavily on those behind ‘Trinamool-run syndicates’ and said that they had the last chance to avoid facing the rule of law. “Surrender at your nearest police stations before April 23. Because after May 4, none of you will be spared,” he said. **Mamata retorts** Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee responded to the charge of the Prime Minister and said that after losing in Parliament, he was attempting a ‘face-saving’ exercise. “Being Prime Minister of the country, you are using a government machinery like Doordarshan for spreading political misinformation. The women’s reservation Bill was passed on September 25, 2023, with 450 votes in favour. Where has the Bill disappeared? Why was no notification done?” Ms. Banerjee said. She said the real game plan was not the interest of women but delimitation and increasing the number of Lok Sabha seats to 850.

Shah slams Cong., DMK for opposing Bill in Lok Sabha

The Hindu Bureau
ERODE

BJP leader and Union Home Minister Amit Shah said on Sunday that the actions of the Congress and the DMK in opposing the Constitution Amendment Bill linked to delimitation would not be tolerated under any circumstances. The proposed legislation will be passed to ensure significant benefits for women, he said at the campaign for the party’s Makkurichi Assembly constituency candidate, S. Kirthika, at Sivagiri. He said the Centre introduced the Bill in Parliament to ensure greater participation of women in the political process but it was obstructed by the Congress and the DMK. Efforts to expand women’s representation in Parliament and the Assemblies were thwarted by these parties, he said. Steps linked to delimitation and constituency restructuring were proposed to enhance women’s representation but were opposed with a “narrow objective” to prevent an increase in seats in Tamil Nadu and deny women greater opportunities, Mr. Shah said.



Amit Shah

Women had been denied crucial opportunities due to the actions of the Congress and the DMK, and such practices will not be tolerated, he added. Mr. Shah said the AIADMK-led National Democratic Alliance would form the government in the State and “put a full stop” to corruption under the DMK regime. **Law and order situation** The law and order situation in the State had deteriorated. A new government will restore effective governance. The “glories and distinctions” once associated with the State will be revived, he said. Targeting Chief Minister M.K. Stalin, Mr. Shah said his sole aim was to make his son, Udhayanidhi Stalin, the next Chief Minister.

Following massive online backlash over a purported internal grooming document, eyewear retailer Lenskart has issued a public apology and released a standardised 'In-Store Style Guide' that allows employees to wear religious and cultural symbols at work. The new policy "explicitly and unambiguously" welcomes all symbols of faith carried by team members, including the bindi, *tilak*, *sindoor*, *kalawa*, *mangalsutra*, *kada*, *hijab*, and *turban*. Addressing the uproar a few days ago, Lenskart founder Peyush Bansal had stepped in to clarify that the viral document was an "outdated version" and did not reflect the company's current stance. PTI

Two Indian men have been shot dead in Italy's Covo in Bergamo province just as they were leaving a warehouse used as a place of worship during a gathering for Vaisakhi festival, local media reported on Sunday . The attack occurred on April 17, a few minutes before midnight in the square in front of the Gurdwara Mata Sahib Kaur Ji in the industrial area of the town, according to *La Sicilia* newspaper. The deceased were identified as Raginder Singh, 48, a resident of Covo, and Gurmit Singh, 48, from Agnadello. The assailant allegedly approached the men, opened fire and then fled in a car, the paper reported. 71

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Why mis-selling takes place

COVERNOTE

K. Nitya Kalyani

When a policy is sold under the fog of misinformation, ignorance is being taken advantage of. Also your trust, preconceptions and urgency.

It is a deception from which you will wake up only months or years later. That’s when you notice the returns are not as implied, exclusions turn apparent, exit options carry a price tag or premium is more than you expected. Buying an insurance policy is not a decision you can reverse easily. If you are in the claims zone, it may be too late. You are one unhappy customer, but hardly the only one. Why does this happen? Why sell on pretence? Follow the money, said a famous detective. Mis-selling is to maximise sellers’ commissions, for incentives and to reach insurer’s product-specific goals .

Hidden agenda

The seller is handling a ‘difficult-to-sell’ product under pressure to earn commission. His income and career



Vested interest: Policy sold can likely earn more commission. GETTYIMAGES/ISTOCK

depend on the sale even if under a pretence. There could be a hidden agenda in the way commissions are structured. Not all policies are equally profitable for the seller. Endowments, money-back and certainly unit-linked covers get more commissions than term covers. The policy pushed may be the one fetching more commission.

The hidden agenda could originate with the insurer. Targets are stiff and can often be product specific. For example, a newly-launched product everyone is under orders to sell.

Sellers don’t receive a fixed salary and what they sell determines earnings. Sales goals are unforgiving and agents can lose licence for underperforming. Hence, insurance is hard-sold and the seller is persistent.

Non-monetary benefits

Reaching targets brings non-monetary benefits such as recognition and opportunities to attend professional conventions and meetings. Success opens doors within the insurer and industry to the world of prospective clients. Networking is everything in sales and insurance, a prime example.

And then there are the priorities of the insurance company itself. New products are introduced with premium rates calculated on several assumptions, including break-even sales levels. The best opportunity to reach the number is in the launch phase since a new policy/scheme gets maximum advertising and marketing attention and the sales teams are pumped up with enthusiasm.

Hype, misinformation

Misinformation is rarely far behind when hype is involved. This combined with target pressure makes mis-selling an easy way to succeed.

Aren’t there checks and balances in the system? Definitely. The regulator speaks out against mis-selling. Suitability norms, systemic checks and documentation have been put in place to curb them.

Customers have to sign declarations about disclosure and agents are evaluated on persistence of portfolios not only sales volumes.

What can you do to avoid being a victim of mis-selling and how do the industry and regulations help you or do they fall short? We will see in the forthcoming instalment of CoverNote.

(The writer is a business journalist specialising in insurance & corporate history)

Send queries on personal finance and investing to the moneywise@thehindu.co.in ID. Our experts in personal finance will respond to select queries, but will not give specific recommendations for investment in a particular mutual fund, share or fixed deposit.



ILLUSTRATION- SAAI

Where money sits, what it becomes, why it matters?

Is your wealth a thriving organism or a ticking time bomb? Calculate the Finosis ‘deep tissue scan’ to see if your money is collecting moss or building muscle to survive a financial heart attack

FINOSIS SCORE II

Vaishali R. Venkat

Last week, I introduced the first layer of Finosis Score, which was primarily about checking the financial pulse and stabilising the position. This week, I want to take you deeper into Layer 2 of the Finosis Score, what I call the ‘deep tissue scan’. Now that we have addressed the basic building blocks such as debt, insurance, skill sets, behaviour, etc., it is high time we looked at the ‘metabolic efficiency’ of the financial organism.

Even the so-called healthy person with a strong pulse can be sluggish if he/she suffers from poor nutrition or chronic over strain. In this layer, our diagnosis extends beyond money as we look at its velocity, purpose, and endurance. We are no longer just checking if the ‘patient’ is breathing; we are examining the quality of his/her financial DNA. Let’s begin the scan...

Vital metabolism

Merely having blood isn’t enough; it must not clot, but circulate throughout the body to sustain healthy life. Likewise, simply piling up money is like “clotting of wealth”.

For wealth to grow healthy, it must be actively working for you even while you sleep, not just sitting idle and eroding. To check your wealth’s “metabolic efficiency,” let’s examine



Asset Allocation is an important factor in your financial journey, accounting for almost 90% of the variability in portfolio’s performance over time

four high-resolution indicators: Asset Allocation (the nutrient mix), Goal Alignment (the purpose of the cells), Liquidity (the blood flow) and Inflation Protection (the immune system). Each indicator is rated on a scale of 1 to 10, giving a total score out of 40, which can then be scaled up to 100.

Asset Allocation

It is the art of deciding how much of your money wears a ‘helmet’ (FD, RD, bank balance, government bonds) and how much is out there “climbing rocky mountains” (stocks or other high-risk assets). It is an important factor in your financial journey, accounting for almost 90% of the variability in portfolio’s performance over time. To score this, look for concentration risk; you earn a 2 if more than 80% of wealth is trapped in one place.

Score 5 or 6 means you have variety, but your assets are vulnerable to the same systemic shock. For instance, owning five different equity funds and all crash at once when market nosedives, or having multiple properties in different cities that lose rental in-



The scores are only indicative. Minor variations are natural, but a low score should not be equated with a strong one and vice-versa

come during a pandemic or other crisis. You score 8 or above only when you truly diversify across at least four unrelated categories such as emergency funds, FD/RDs, government bonds, gold/silver, and stocks, ensuring that all your assets don’t “catch a cold” together so you never have to sell at a loss.

Goal Alignment

Every Rupee needs a “DNA assignment.” To score this, you must match your investment’s tenure to its goal. You earn just 2 if money beyond emergency funds is sitting idle in a savings account or as cash without a defined purpose. A 5 or 6 means your portfolio is only partially linked to goals, creating “blurred lines”, like using a long-term FD meant for your child’s education to fund a car purchase today.

You score 8 or above only when every financial asset is strictly mapped to a timeline and a defined goal such as retirement, children’s education, or a medical buffer.

Inflation Protection

Inflation is the silent virus eating your purchasing

power. You earn a 2 if your money sits in “stagnant water” like cash or bank savings accounts, collecting moss while its real-world value rots. A 5 or 6 means you have “safe” FD/RDs that merely act as a life jacket, which keep your head above water, but you aren’t moving forward.

You score 8 or above when your wealth is led by growth assets such as equities that outpace inflation, with gold and silver acting as a secondary hedge.

Liquidity

This measures how fast you can grab cash in times of need. You earn a 2 if all your wealth is “frozen” in real estate or other bonds with lock-in periods. A 5 or 6 applies to FDs or RDs, where you can access cash but only by paying a penalty or losing interest. You score 8 or above only for cash equivalent assets (like high-interest savings or Liquid Funds) which provide instant cash with zero risk to your principal.

The scores are only indicative and not absolute. Minor variations are natural, but a low score should not be equated with a strong one, and vice-versa. With that in mind, take a pen and paper, work through the scores, and see what the Finosis Score has in store for you.

Does your financial genie summon wealth, or just spin bubbles?

(The writer is an NISM & CRISIL-certified Wealth Manager and certified in NISM’s Research Analyst module)

Bank Fixed Deposit Rates

Bank Name	Interest Rates (%)			
	Highest Slab	1-year Tenure	3-year Tenure	5-year Tenure
Small Finance Banks				
AU Small Finance Bank	7.10	6.35	7.10	6.75
Equitas Small Finance Bank	7.40	6.90	7.00	7.00
ESAF Small Finance Bank	8.00	4.75	6.00	5.75
Jana Small Finance Bank	7.77	7.00	7.50	7.77
Shivalik Small Finance Bank	7.80	6.00	6.75	6.25
slice Small Finance Bank	7.75	6.25	7.50	7.00
Suryoday Small Finance Bank	8.10	7.25	7.25	7.90
Ujjivan Small Finance Bank	7.45	7.25	7.20	7.20
Utkarsh Small Finance Bank	7.50	6.00	7.50	7.00
Private Sector Banks				
Axis Bank	6.45	6.25	6.45	6.45
Bandhan Bank	7.25	7.00	7.25	5.85
City Union Bank	7.00	6.80	6.50	6.25
CSB Bank	7.35	5.00	5.75	5.75
DBS Bank	6.60	6.30	6.40	6.25
DCB Bank	7.15	6.90	7.00	7.15
Federal Bank	6.75	6.25	6.75	6.40
HDFC Bank	6.50	6.25	6.45	6.40
ICICI Bank	6.50	6.25	6.45	6.50
IDFC FIRST Bank	7.40	6.50	7.00	7.00
Indusind Bank	7.00	6.75	6.90	6.65

Bank Name	Interest Rates (%)			
	Highest Slab	1-year Tenure	3-year Tenure	5-year Tenure
Public Sector Banks				
Jammu & Kashmir Bank	7.25	6.75	6.65	6.60
IDBI Bank	6.50	6.20	6.35	6.25
Karnataka Bank	6.75	6.50	6.15	6.15
Kotak Mahindra Bank	6.80	6.50	6.40	6.25
RBL Bank	7.20	7.00	7.20	6.70
SBM Bank India	7.85	7.10	7.10	7.00
South Indian Bank	6.80	6.25	6.20	5.70
Tamilnad Mercantile Bank	7.25	6.80	6.70	6.70
YES Bank	7.00	6.65	7.00	6.75
Public Sector Banks				
Bank of Baroda	6.45	6.10	6.25	6.30
Bank of India	6.60	6.25	6.25	6.00
Bank of Maharashtra	6.65	6.20	5.25	5.00
Canara Bank	6.60	6.25	6.25	6.25
Central Bank of India	6.50	6.20	6.00	6.00
Indian Bank	6.60	6.10	6.05	6.00
Indian Overseas Bank	6.60	6.50	6.10	6.10
Punjab National Bank	6.60	6.25	6.30	6.10
Punjab & Sind Bank	6.75	5.85	5.85	5.95
State Bank of India	6.45	6.25	6.30	6.05
Union Bank of India	6.60	6.30	6.25	6.00

Home Loan Interest Rates

Name of Lender	Loan Amount (Rs.)		
	Upto 30 lakh	Above 30 lakh & upto 75 lakh	Above 75 lakh
(In %)			
Public Sector Banks			
State Bank of India	7.25-8.95	7.25-8.95	7.25-8.95
Bank of Baroda	7.20-9.00	7.20-9.00	7.20-9.25
Union Bank of India*	7.15-9.50	7.15-9.50	7.15-9.50
Punjab National Bank	7.30-9.30	7.25-9.20	7.25-9.20
Bank of India	7.10-10.00	7.10-10.00	7.10-10.25
Bank of Maharashtra	7.10-9.90	7.10-9.90	7.10-9.90
Punjab and Sind Bank	7.30-10.70	7.30-10.70	7.30-10.70
Indian Overseas Bank	7.10 #	7.10 #	7.10 #
Indian Bank	7.15-9.55	7.15-9.55	7.15-9.55
Central Bank of India	7.10-9.15	7.10-9.15	7.10-9.15
Private Sector Banks			
Kotak Mahindra Bank	7.70 #	7.70 #	7.70 #
ICICI Bank	7.45 #	7.45 #	7.45 #
Axis Bank	8.00-11.90	8.00-11.90	8.00 - 9.10
HSBC Bank	7.45 #	7.45 #	7.45 #
South Indian Bank	7.20 #	7.20 #	7.20 #
Karur Vysya Bank	8.50-10.65	8.50-10.65	8.50-10.65
Karnataka Bank	7.31-11.69	7.31-11.69	7.31-11.69

Name of Lender	Loan Amount (Rs.)		
	Upto 30 lakh	Above 30 lakh & upto 75 lakh	Above 75 lakh
(In %)			
Housing Finance Companies (HFCs)			
Federal Bank	8.30 - 10.75	7.30 - 10.75	7.30 - 9.75
Tamilnad Mercantile Bank	7.90 - 9.30	7.90 - 9.30	7.90 - 9.30
Bandhan Bank	8.41-12.58	8.41-12.58	8.41-12.58
RBL Bank	8.20 #	8.20 #	8.20 #
CSB Bank	8.30 #	8.30 #	8.30 #
HDFC Bank	7.75 #	7.75 #	7.75 #
City Union Bank	8.25-9.50	8.50-10.00	8.75-10.50
Housing Finance Companies (HFCs)			
LIC Housing Finance	7.15 #	7.15 #	7.15 #
Bajaj Housing Finance	7.15 #	7.15 #	7.15 #
Tata Capital	7.50 #	7.50 #	7.50 #
PNB Housing Finance	7.50 #	7.50 #	7.50 #
GIC Housing Finance	8.20 #	8.20 #	8.20 #
SMFG India Home Finance	10.00 #	10.00 #	10.00 #
Aditya Birla Capital	7.75 #	7.75 #	7.75 #
ICICI Home Finance	7.50 #	7.50 #	7.50 #
Godrej Housing Finance	7.60 #	7.60 #	7.60 #
*Extra interest rate concession of 0.05% to borrowers opting for insurance policy #Onwards Rates as on April 15 Source:Paisabazaar.com			

SEOUL

N. Korea fires short-range ballistic missiles toward eastern waters



AFP

North Korea launched multiple short-range ballistic missiles toward the sea on Sunday, its neighbours said, days after the UN's nuclear watchdog warned that North Korea was making "very serious" advances in efforts to build nuclear weapons. The missiles flew about 140 km toward the country's eastern waters. AP

ATHENS

France and Greece to renew their defence pact for another five years



AFP

French President Emmanuel Macron will travel to Greece to renew a security pact between the two countries against the backdrop of the war in Iran, a Greek government official said on Sunday. Mr. Macron's visit to Greece on April 24-25 will renew the pact for a further five years, with an automatic renewal thereafter. REUTERS

JERUSALEM

Argentina's Milei says U.S.-Israel war against Iran 'right thing to do'



REUTERS

Argentine President Javier Milei declared on Sunday that the joint U.S.-Israel war against Iran was the "right thing to do", as he signed on to the Isaac Accords, aimed at deepening ties between Israel and Latin American countries. He also highlighted his government's earlier decision to designate the IRGC a "terrorist organisation". AFP

KYIV

Zelenskyy condemns extension of sanctions waiver on Russian oil



AFP

Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy on Sunday condemned the easing of sanctions on Russian oil after the United States extended a waiver meant to soften surging energy prices driven by the West Asia war. "Every dollar paid for Russian oil is money for the war," Mr. Zelenskyy said in a post on X. AFP

Israel says it will use 'full force' in Lebanon if soldiers face any threat

Israel Katz says IDF can strike both on the ground and from the air to protect soldiers in Lebanon, even during ceasefire; he also orders demolitions of buildings and roads, saying they endangered soldiers; another Israeli soldier killed in Lebanon

Agence France-Presse
SA NUR

Israeli Defence Minister Israel Katz said on Sunday that the military had been instructed to use "full force" in Lebanon – even during the ongoing ceasefire – should Israeli troops face any threat. "Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu and I have instructed the IDF to act with full force, both on the ground and from the air, including during the ceasefire, in order to protect our soldiers in Lebanon from any threat," Mr. Katz said at a function in the occupied West Bank. He said that the military



Wiped out: A resident walks on the rubble of a building destroyed in an Israeli air strike in Tyre, southern Lebanon, on Sunday. AP

had also been ordered to demolish any structure or roads that were "booby-trapped" and threatened soldiers. The aim is "to remove the houses in the vil-

lages near the border that served in every respect as Hezbollah terror outposts and threatened Israeli communities," Mr. Katz added. A firefighter works at a compound hit during overnight Russian drone strikes in the Odesa region of Ukraine. REUTERS

An Israeli soldier was killed in southern Lebanon on Friday – the day a 10-day ceasefire between Israel and Lebanon came into effect – when he entered a booby-trapped building, the military reported. Mr. Katz has repeatedly said Israel would demolish houses along the border as part of efforts to establish a security zone in southern Lebanon. On Saturday, Israeli forces carried out demolitions in the town of Bint Jbeil, the scene of intense fighting with Hezbollah prior to the recently agreed ceasefire. "The overarching goal

of the campaign in Lebanon is the disarmament of Hezbollah and the removal of threat to northern communities, through a combination of military and diplomatic measures," Mr. Katz said. "If the Lebanese government continues to fail to uphold its obligations – the IDF will do so through continued military action." Lebanon was drawn into the West Asia war in early March when the Tehran-backed Hezbollah launched rockets towards Israel in support of Iran. Israel responded with massive strikes across Lebanon and an invasion of southern Lebanon.

U.K. police probing 'Iran proxies' for arson attacks

Associated Press
LONDON

British police said on Sunday they are investigating whether a string of arson attacks on Jewish sites in London are the work of Iranian proxies. The Metropolitan Police force says counterterror officers are probing the attacks on synagogues and other sites linked to the Jewish community, as well as an attack on a Persian-language media company. No one has been injured in the blazes, the latest of which caused minor damage to a north London synagogue on Saturday night. Police said the attacks had been claimed by a group calling itself Harakat Ashab al-Yamin al-Islamia.

Russian hits kill at least 2 persons as Ukraine strikes Russian drone factory

Associated Press
KYIV

Russian strikes killed at least two persons in Ukraine, officials said on Sunday, as Ukraine's military struck a drone factory in southwestern Russia. A "massive" nighttime drone strike on Chernihiv in northern Ukraine killed a 16-year-old boy and wounded four others, according to the head of the city's military administration. Rescuers found the teenager's body as they cleared away rubble, Dmytro Bryzhynskiy reported on Telegram on Sunday morning. He said the drone strike also wounded three women and one man. Several houses were set on fire, he added. Russian drones also at-



A firefighter works at a compound hit during overnight Russian drone strikes in the Odesa region of Ukraine. REUTERS

tacked the southern city of Kherson on Sunday, local officials reported. A man died of his wounds after a drone hit a van driving through the city centre, according to Oleksandr Prokudin, the head of the regional administration. A second man was hospitalised with blast injuries, regional authorities said. Russia launched 236 drones into Ukrainian territory overnight into Sunday, Ukraine's air force reported. Of those, 203 drones were shot down while 32 hit targets in 18 separate locations, it said. Meanwhile, Ukraine hit a drone factory in the city of Taganrog, Ukraine's General Staff reported.

The site lies some 55 km east of Russian-occupied eastern Ukraine in southwestern Russia. According to the military, Ukrainian drones sparked a fire at the Atlant Aero factory, which designs and produces strike and reconnaissance drones, as well as components for more powerful UAVs that can carry guided bombs weighing up to 250 kg. Ukraine's navy said it carried out the attack on the drone factory in southern Russia, using domestically manufactured Neptune cruise missiles. "This defence enterprise is an important part of the Russian military-industrial complex, where drones were developed and manufactured," the navy said in an online post.

Bulgaria votes as pro-Russian ex-President leads the polls

Reuters
SOFIA

Bulgarians went to the polls on Sunday in the eighth parliamentary election in five years, with the clear frontrunner, pro-Russian former President Rumen Radev, promising to end a spiral of weak, short-lived governments and stamp out widespread corruption. Mr. Radev, a eurosceptic former fighter pilot who opposes military support for Ukraine's war effort against Moscow, stepped down from the presidency in January to run in the election, which comes after mass protests forced

member of the European Union and NATO, adopted the euro in January. The previous government fell amid protests against a new Budget proposing tax rises and higher social security contributions. That and the recent political crisis appear to be more important to voters than Mr. Radev's calls to improve relations with Moscow or resume Russian oil and gas flows to Europe. Opinion polls on Friday showed Radev's Progressive Bulgaria securing about 35% of the vote, up from a month ago. If confirmed, that would mark one of the strongest results by a single party in years.

Opinion polls showed Radev's Progressive Bulgaria securing about 35% of vote, up from a month ago

out the previous government in December. A slick social media campaign, deep coffers and a pledge of stability have boosted Mr. Radev's support in the Balkan country of about 6.5 million, where voters are weary of repeated snap polls and a small group of veteran politicians widely seen as corrupt. The cost of living is also an issue since Bulgaria, a



The Kerala Minerals and Metals Ltd
(A Govt. of Kerala Undertaking), Sankaramonglam, Kollam 691583
Phone : 0476-2651215 to 217, E-Mail : mdg@kmmll.com

TENDER NOTICE
For more details please visit E-Tendering Portal, <https://etenders.kerala.gov.in> or www.kmmll.com
S.No. Tender Id. Items
1 2026_KMML_848529_1 Supply of Plate Inconel 600
2 2026_KMML_848495_1 Supply of Sodium Hexa Meta Phosphate
3 2026_KMML_848309_1 Supply of key Bricks
Chavara 20.04.2026 Sd/- Managing Director for The Kerala Minerals and Metals Ltd

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कौशल, नियोजन एवं उद्यमिता विभाग
प्राविधिक शिक्षा निदेशालय, राजस्थान, जोधपुर
W-6, गौरव-पथ, जोधपुर Ph No. 0291-2432290, Fax: 0291-2632339,
Email: scheme.dot@rajasthan.gov.in
No. DTE/T-4 (SCHEME)/PMPES/4324(3)/2026/69097 दिनांक: 13.04.2026
Corrigendum-IV
ई-निविदा सूचना संख्या 01/2025-26 में निम्नानुसार संशोधन किये जा रहे हैं:-
S.N. UBN No. Corrigendum
01 UBN No. TET2526SLO800140 RFP में निम्नसार आवश्यक संशोधन किये जा रहे हैं:-
1. Pre-Bid Conference - 24.04.2026
2. Authority response to queries latest by 28.04.2026
3. Authority's additional response, if any 06.05.2026
4. Bid due date - 27.05.2026
5. Opening of Technical Bids - 27.05.2026
6. Announcement of qualified Bidders - 11.06.2026
7. Opening of Financial Bid - 18.06.2026
8. Letter of Award (LOA) - Within 30 days of opening of Financial Bid.
9. Validity of Bids - 120 days of Bid Due Date.
10. Signing of License Agreement- within 30 days of award of LOA
अन्य नियम एवं शर्तें पूर्ववत् रहेंगी।
DIPIR/C/6983/26 निदेशक (प्रशिक्षण)



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तिरुवनन्तपुरम

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ADVERTISEMENT NO. VSSC-339 DATED 20.04.2026
निम्नलिखित पदों के लिए ऑन-लाइन आवेदन आमंत्रित करता है
INVITES ONLINE APPLICATIONS FOR THE FOLLOWING POSITION

पद सं. Position No	पद का नाम Name of Position	अनिवार्य योग्यताएं Essential Qualifications	रिक्तियों की संख्या No. of Vacancies
01/2026	कनिष्ठ अध्येता (जेआरएफ) Junior Research Fellow (JRF)	(a) सभी सेमेस्टर्स के औसत के रूप में कुल न्यूनतम 60% अंक या 10 पॉइंट स्कैल या समकक्ष पर 6.5 का सीजीपीए / सीपीआइ वर्गीकरण सहित भौतिकी / अनुप्रयुक्त भौतिकी / इंजीनियरी भौतिकी / अंतरिक्ष भौतिकी / वायुमंडलीय विज्ञान / मौसम विज्ञान ग्रहण विज्ञान या वायुमंडलीय विज्ञान / अंतरिक्ष विज्ञान / ग्रहण विज्ञान / अनुप्रयुक्त भौतिकी में एम.एस / एम.ई / एम.टेक M.Sc. Degree in Physics / Applied Physics / Engineering Physics / Space Physics / Atmospheric Science / Meteorology / Planetary Sciences OR M.S / M.E / M.Tech in Atmospheric Science / Space Science / Planetary Science / Applied Physics / Engineering Physics with minimum 60% marks as average of all semesters in aggregate or CGPA / CPI grading of 6.5 on a 10 point scale or equivalent. (b) आवेदकों को निम्नलिखितों में से एक में भी योग्यता प्राप्त होनी चाहिए / Applicants should also have qualified one of the following: 1. नेट-लेक्चरशिप सहित सी एस आइ आर-यूजीसी राष्ट्रीय पात्रता परीक्षा / CSIR-UGC National Eligibility Test, including NET-Lecturehip. 2. एम्एचआरडी द्वारा आयोजित इंजीनियरी में स्नातक अभिषमता परीक्षा (गेट)/ Graduate Aptitude Test in Engineering (GATE) conducted by MHRD. 3. जोइंट एंट्रन्स स्क्रीनिंग टेस्ट (जेईएसटी) / Joint Entrance Screening Test (JEST)	08

विस्तृत विज्ञापन वीएसएससी वेबसाइट <https://www.vssc.gov.in> में दिया जाएगा। उपर्युक्त पदों के लिए आवेदन केवल ऑन-लाइन प्राप्त किए जाएंगे। ऑन-लाइन आवेदन प्रस्तुत करने के लिए वेबसाइट दिनांक 20.04.2026 को 1000 बजे से दिनांक 04.05.2026 को 1700 बजे तक खुला रहेगा।

Detailed advertisement will be hosted in VSSC website <https://www.vssc.gov.in>. Applications for the above positions will be received on-line only. The website will be open for submission of online application from 1000 hours on 20.04.2026 to 1700 hours on 04.05.2026.

सरकार एक ऐसे कार्यबल का प्रयास करती है जो लिंग संतुलन को अभिव्यक्ति करता है तथा महिला अभ्यर्थियों को आवेदन देने हेतु प्रोत्साहित किया जाता है। Government strives to have a workforce which reflects gender balance and women candidates are encouraged to apply

OOPS!

Rinku cashes in as Burger’s butter fingers come back to haunt Royals



PTI

Nandre Burger dropped a sitter at short third to grant Rinku Singh a lifeline on eight. While that may have tilted the momentum towards KKR, the South African would’ve perhaps thanked the heavens for having avoided getting scratched by the ‘invisible sword’ of bowler Ravindra Jadeja, who sent the nastiest of glares Burger’s way.

WORRISOME

In a team full of marauding batters, Royals skipper Parag yet to fire



RITU RAJ KONWAR

It must be difficult for Riyan Parag to check his batting average this season, especially when RR opening pair of Yashasvi Jaiswal and Vaibhav Suryavanshi seem like an unstoppable force. But what was 12.25 ahead of the game against KKR on Sunday slipped further to 12.20. Classic case of death by decimal and a bit of drama.

BIG BOOST

Sri Lanka fast bowler Pathirana joins Knight Riders squad



FILE PHOTO

Sri Lanka pacer Matheesha Pathirana has finally joined Kolkata Knight Riders for IPL 2026. Having recovered from a calf strain sustained in the T20 World Cup, Pathirana cleared the mandatory fitness test by Sri Lanka Cricket before receiving a no-objection certificate. He linked up with the squad on Sunday.

POSITIVE SIGNS

Dhoni just needs to get confidence in his running, says Hussey



FILE PHOTO: R. RAGU

He’s (M.S. Dhoni) batting well, he even walked out of the nets early because he was very happy with where his batting is at. If he’s going to bat towards the back end, he’s going to have to scurry for those twos. He just needs to get confidence in his running (between the wickets) — Mike Hussey on Dhoni.

Varun, Rinku-Anukul duo fashion KKR’s first win

The spinner, along with Narine and Tyagi, restricts Royals after a breezy opening stand by JaiSurya; the two left-handers add 76 off just 37 balls to lift home team from 85 for six in pursuit of 156

IPL-19

Santadeep Dev
KOLKATA

Kolkata Knight Riders (KKR), at rock bottom, finally had some light creep in through the crevice on Sunday as it bagged its first win and much-needed two points in the ongoing IPL 2026.

KKR made heavy weather of the modest target of 156 set by Rajasthan Royals (RR), but celebrated with the fervour of a title triumph at Eden Gardens.

It also snapped an eight-game winless run across two seasons for the home team.

Rinku Singh, who made the most of an early reprieve by Nandre Burger, and Anukul Roy guided KKR over the line.

The two southpaws added 76 off just 37 balls after the three-time champion had slumped to 85 for six.

Varun’s feat

Earlier, after opting to bat, RR’s opening duo JaiSurya had an underwhelming outing by its high standard. While going at a run rate of over nine, Vaibhav Suryavanshi fell four short of a half-century. Varun Chakaravarthy was the one happy to oblige, the 15-year-old’s being his 200th T20 wicket.



Huge impact: Varun’s triple strike put the brakes on RR. Rinku delivered at the crunch for KKR after Jurel’s brilliance sent back the dangerous Green. RITU RAJ KONWAR

When Sunil Narine’s five dot balls to Suryavanshi in the fifth over felt like a minor power outage, Ajinkya Rahane would

have felt KKR had missed a trick by not opening with spin on a dry-as-bone surface.

But once Varun re-

turned to have Dhruv Jurel stumped and Narine dismissed Yashasvi Jaiswal less than an over later, the KKR captain could finally

move on from that thought.

Riyan Parag’s struggles continued as Varun speared in one that

cramped him for room. Narine tightened the chokehold further, inducing Donovan Ferreira to tap the final ball of his spell



SCOREBOARD

RAJASTHAN ROYALS
Yashasvi Jaiswal c Rahane b Narine 39 (29b, 4x4, 2x6), Vaibhav Suryavanshi c Ramandeep b Varun 46 (28b, 6x4, 2x6), Dhruv Jurel st. Seifert b Varun 5 (7b), Riyan Parag b Varun 12 (14b, 1x4), Shimron Hetmyer c Raghuvanshi b Tyagi 15 (18b), Donovan Ferreira c & b Narine 7 (7b, 1x6), Ravindra Jadeja c Green b Tyagi 9 (7b, 1x4), Jofra Archer run out 8 (5b, 1x4), Ravi Bishnoi c Seifert b Tyagi 0 (2b), Brijesh Sharma (not out) 1 (3b); Extras (b-1, lb-2, w-10); 13; Total (for nine wkts. in 20 overs): 155.

FALL OF WICKETS
1-81 (Suryavanshi, 8.4 overs), 2-97 (Jurel, 10.3), 3-99 (Jaiswal, 11.2), 4-117 (Parag, 14.4), 5-124 (Ferreira, 15.6), 6-144 (Jadeja, 18.1), 7-146 (Hetmyer, 18.3), 8-146 (Bishnoi, 18.5), 9-155 (Archer, 19.6).

KNIGHT RIDERS BOWLING
Vaibhav 4-0-37-0, Tyagi 4-0-22-3, Green 2-0-27-0, Narine 4-0-26-2, Varun 4-0-14-3, Ramandeep 2-0-26-0.

KOLKATA KNIGHT RIDERS
Tim Seifert b Archer 0 (1b), Ajinkya Rahane c Jurel b Burger 0 (2b), Angkrish Raghuvanshi

(Impact Player for Varun) lbw b Jadeja 10 (19b, 1x4), Cameron Green st. Jurel b Bishnoi 27 (13b, 4x4, 1x6), Rovman Powell c Ferreira b Jadeja 23 (20b, 2x4, 1x6), Rinku Singh (not out) 53 (34b, 5x4, 2x6), Ramandeep Singh b Yash Raj 10 (13b, 1x4), Anukul Roy (not out) 29 (16b, 1x4, 2x6); Extras (lb-1, w-8); 9; Total (for six wkts. in 19.4 overs): 161.

FALL OF WICKETS
1-0 (Seifert, 0.1), 2-5 (Rahane, 1.2), 3-37 (Green, 4.3), 4-52 (Raghuvanshi, 6.6), 5-70 (Powell, 10.1), 6-85 (Ramandeep, 13.3).

ROYALS BOWLING
Archer 4-0-35-1, Burger 2-0-20-1, Bishnoi 4-0-41-1, Yash Raj

(Impact Player for Suryavanshi) 4-0-25-1, Jadeja 3-0-8-2, Parag 1-0-10-0, Brijesh 1-4-0-21-0.

Toss: RR; PoM: Varun. KKR won by four wickets with two balls to spare.

Next assignment

RR: April 22 vs. LSG
Lucknow, 7.30 p.m.

KKR: April 26 vs. LSG
Lucknow, 7.30 p.m.

straight back to him.

And just when it seemed like a spinners’ union meeting, Kartik Tyagi crashed the party with three wickets in the penultimate over to register his best T20 figures.

Disastrous start

In reply, KKR got off to a horrid start with Tim Seifert and Ajinkya Rahane falling for ducks.

Angkrish Raghuvanshi never got going, and Cameron Green, fresh off a 79 against Gujarat Titans, departed courtesy of some nifty glove-work from Jurel. Meanwhile, Rovman Powell’s stay was cut short by Ravindra Jadeja’s guile.

However, a moment of luck and the brilliance of Rinku and Anukul turned it around for the Knight Riders.

Priyansh-Connolly assault leaves the Super Giants stunned

Dhruva Prasad
NEW CHANDIGARH

Punjab Kings remained unbeaten and consolidated its position at the top of the IPL standings with a commanding 54-run win over Lucknow Super Giants at the Maharaja Yadavindra Singh Stadium on Sunday.

The PBKS bowlers rose in unison after Priyansh Arya and Cooper Connolly put on a blistering 182-run second-wicket partnership off just 80 balls to power the host to 254 for seven, the highest score of the season. In reply LSG was standing at 61, with Ayush Badoni’s promotion as opener working to an extent, before V. Vyshak dismissed him off the last ball of the PowerPlay.

Rishabh Pant’s consecutive sixes off Marco Jansen in the following over, including a trademark one-handed swing that cleared long-on, kept Super Giants’ hopes alive. However, with Pant and Nicholas Pooran falling in quick succession, and 113 runs to get from the last five overs, Super Giants were fighting a battle which was nearly impossible to win.

Earlier, batting first for the first time in this IPL, Kings rode on magnificent knocks from Priyansh and



Left is right: Priyansh and Connolly sent the Lucknow bowlers on a leather hunt. SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP

Connolly. The left-handed duo’s assault on a hapless LSG attack was of such magnitude that the final five overs, which yielded 61 runs, seemed sedate in comparison.

PBKS was roaring at 179 for one after 13 overs, following a 32-run over bowled by Aiden Markram, which contained five sixes.

Prince Yadav, the only Super Giants bowler who escaped the host’s wrath, put the skids on the scoring rate by dismissing Connolly with a short ball, before M. Siddharth prised out Priyansh.

After LSG elected to bowl, Mohammed Shami sent back the in-form Prabhsimran Singh for a

golden duck with an out-swing in the first over, while Prince kept Connolly quiet. Once the field opened up, Connolly, who was lucky not to have a leg-before appeal reviewed when he was on four, made Pant & Co. pay and raised a 35-ball fifty.

Priyansh, operating on a wholly different wave-

length, brought up his half-century off just 19 balls to set the perfect launchpad for Punjab’s fifth win.

Next assignment

LSG: April 22 vs. RR
Lucknow, 7.30 p.m.

PBKs: April 25 vs. DC
Delhi, 3.30 p.m.

SCOREBOARD

PUNJAB KINGS
Priyansh Arya c Marsh b Siddharth 93 (37b, 4x4, 9x6), Prabhsimran Singh c Marsh b Shami 0 (1b), Cooper Connolly c Siddharth b Prince 87 (46b, 8x4, 7x6), Shreyas Iyer c Shami b Mohsin 5 (6b), Marcus Stoinis run out 29 (16b, 2x4, 2x6), Nehal Wadhwa c Pooran b Siddharth 13 (7b, 1x4, 1x6), Shashank Singh c Markram b Prince 17 (6b, 1x4, 2x6), Marco Jansen (not out) 1 (1b); Extras (lb-3, w-6); 9; Total (for seven wkts. in 20 overs): 254.

FALL OF WICKETS
1-3 (Prabhsimran, 0.3 overs), 2-185 (Connolly, 13.5), 3-187 (Priyansh, 14.2), 4-193 (Shreyas, 15.2), 5-208 (Wadhwa, 16.5), 6-252 (Shashank, 19.4), 7-254 (Stoinis, 19.6).

SUPER GIANTS BOWLING
Shami 4-0-56-1, Mohsin 4-0-43-1, Prince 4-0-25-2, Badoni 1-0-14-0, Avesh 3-0-46-0, Siddharth 3-0-35-2, Markram 1-0-32-0.

LUCKNOW SUPER GIANTS
Mitchell Marsh c Bartlett b Chahal 40 (28b, 3x4, 2x6), Ayush Badoni c Bartlett b Vyshak 35 (21b, 5x4, 1x6), Rishabh Pant c Prabhsimran b Arshdeep 43 (23b, 1x4, 4x6), Nicholas Pooran c Shreyas b Jansen 9 (9b, 1x4), Aiden Markram c Stoinis b Jansen 42 (22b, 3x4, 3x6), Mukul Choudhary (not out) 21 (17b, 1x4, 1x6), Himmat Singh (Impact Player for Mohsin) 1 (1b); Extras (lb-2, nb-1, w-6); 9; Total (for five wkts. in 20 overs): 200.

FALL OF WICKETS
1-61 (Badoni, 5.6), 2-109 (Marsh, 11.1), 3-128 (Pant, 12.4), 4-139 (Pooran, 14.2), 5-199 (Markram, 19.5).

KINGS BOWLING
Arshdeep 4-0-41-1, Bartlett 4-0-54-0, Jansen 4-0-37-2, Vyshak (Impact Player for Wadhwa) 4-0-30-1, Chahal 4-0-36-1.

Toss: LSG; **PoM:** Priyansh. PBKS won by 54 runs.

Points table

	M	W	L	NR	PTS	NRR
Punjab Kings	6	5	0	1	11	1.420
Royal Challengers	6	4	2	0	8	1.171
Rajasthan Royals	6	4	2	0	8	0.599
Sunrisers Hyderabad	6	3	3	0	6	0.566
Delhi Capitals	5	3	2	0	6	0.310
Gujarat Titans	5	3	2	0	6	0.018
Chennai Super Kings	6	2	4	0	4	-0.780
Lucknow Super Giants	6	2	4	0	4	-1.173
Kolkata Knight Riders	7	1	5	1	3	-0.879
Mumbai Indians	5	1	4	0	2	-1.076



Klaassen. NAGARA GOPAL

I need to get the job done, says Klaassen

Anirudh Velamuri
HYDERABAD

While runs continue to flow from Heinrich Klaassen’s bat, his strike-rate has come under scrutiny.

This season, he has scored at 144.39 – significantly lower than his previous highs of over 170.

After SRH’s 10-run win against CSK, Klaassen emphasised that his priority was navigating the team through difficult situations. “I’ve been coming in at situations where we’ve lost four wickets in one or two overs. I cannot go right from the start, I need to get the job done. I don’t care about strike-rates. I know a lot has been said about it, but I’ve been putting the team in good positions”.

INBRIEF



Selection committee chief
Agarkar’s contract renewed

Ajit Agarkar will continue as chairman of the senior selection committee after the BCCI decided to renew his contract for one more year, keeping an eye on the 2027 ODI World Cup. Under Agarkar’s chairmanship, the Indian teams reached four ICC tournament finals between October 2023 and March 2026. “Agarkar didn’t seek extension. A selector can continue up to four years in either junior or senior panel and five years cumulatively across both committees. Hence his contract is being renewed and not extended,” said a senior BCCI source.

Productive weeks for
Balaji and Anirudh

Sriram Balaji and Anirudh Chandrasekar, with their respective partners, had productive weeks as they clinched their 18th and 10th ATP Challenger doubles titles respectively. At the Oeiras Open 3 ATP 125 in Portugal on Saturday, Balaji and Neil Oberleitner of Austria defeated Nicolas Barrientos of Colombia and Ariel Behar of Uruguay 6-7(7), 6-4, [11-9]. It was 36-year-old Balaji’s fourth trophy in 2026 and is likely to push him up to 67 in the rankings, seven shy of his career-best number. At the Busan Open ATP 125 in South Korea on Sunday, Anirudh and Japan’s Takeru Yuzuki overcame Dutchman Jean-Julien Rojer and United States’ Theodore Winegar 4-6, 6-3, [10-7]. It was 27-year-old Anirudh’s first title of the season and is set to help him re-enter the top-100.

LIVE TELECAST

▼ **Bangladesh vs New Zealand:** 2nd ODI, FanCode, 10.30 a.m.
IPL: Star Sports 1 & JioHotstar, 7.30 p.m.
ISL: Sony Sports Ten 2 & FanCode, 7.30 p.m.
Serie A: DAZN, 12.15 a.m. (Tuesday)

A record-extending 35th
Bundesliga title for Bayern

Manchester City posts a vital win over Arsenal in the Premier League race; United and Liverpool firm up their bids for European places; Tottenham remains mired in the relegation zone

EURO LEAGUES

Agence France-Presse
MUNICH

Harry Kane scored his 32nd goal of the campaign as Bayern Munich came from behind to beat Stuttgart 4-2 and claim a record-extending 35th Bundesliga title.

Raphael Guerreiro, Nicolas Jackson and Alphonso Davies joined Kane on the scoresheet, while Chris Fuehrich and Chema Andres scored for the visitor as Bayern won the title with four matches to spare.

Manchester City is breathing down Arsenal’s necks after Erling Haaland’s strike beat the Gunners 2-1 on Sunday to land a potentially decisive blow in the Premier League title race.

Pep Guardiola’s men close to within three points of the leader and have a game in hand with momentum firmly in their favour as Arsenal’s quest for a first league title in 22 years unravels.

Victory over relegation-bound Burnley on Wednesday will take City top for the first time this year.

After finishing second for the past three seasons, Arsenal is at risk of seeing another huge chance to end its long wait to be champion of England slip away.

After Rayan Cherki’s stunning solo effort



Unstoppable: Bayern Munich players celebrate after wrapping up yet another top flight title with four games to spare. REUTERS

opened the scoring, City gifted the visitors a route back into the game when Kai Havertz charged down Gianluigi Donnarumma’s attempted clearance to equalise.

Haaland pounced to sweep in his 34th goal of the season 25 minutes from time before Havertz headed over a glorious chance deep into stoppage time.

Matheus Cunha fired Manchester United towards the Champions League with a 1-0 win at Chelsea on Saturday, while Tottenham remains in the relegation zone after twice blowing the lead to draw with Brighton.

Virgil van Dijk scored a last-gasp winner against Everton on Sunday as Liverpool strengthened its

push for a Champions League spot next season.

On a pivotal day in the English top division, fourth-placed Aston Villa squandered a two-goal lead against Sunderland but scored in stoppage time to win 4-3.

At the other end of the table, Morgan Gibbs-White netted a hat-trick as struggling Nottingham Forest came from behind against Burnley to win 4-1 and heap the pressure on troubled Tottenham.

Napoli could concede the Serie A title to Inter Milan as soon as next week after falling to a 2-0 home defeat at the hands of Lazio on Saturday.

The results: Premier League: Everton 1 (Beto 54) lost to Liverpool 2 (Salah 29, van Dijk

90+10); Nottingham Forest 4 (Gibbs-White 62, 69, 77, Jesus 90+8) bt Burnley 1 (Flemming 45+2); Aston Villa 4 (Watkins 2, 36, Rogers 46, Abraham 90+3) bt Sunderland 3 (Rigg 9, Hume 86, Isidor 87); Manchester City 2 (Cherki 16, Haaland 65) bt Arsenal 1 (Havertz 18).

Serie A: Verona 0 lost to AC Milan 1 (Rabiot 41).

Bundesliga: Bayern Munich 4 (Guerreiro 31, Jackson 33, Davies 37, Kane 52) bt Stuttgart 2 (Fuehrich 21, Andres 88).

On Saturday: Premier League: Tottenham 2 (Porro 39, Simons 77) drew with Brighton 2 (Mitoma 45+3, Rutter 90+5); Chelsea 0 lost to Manchester United 1 (Cunha 43). Serie A: Napoli 0 lost to Lazio 2 (Cancellieri 6, Basic 57); Roma 1 (Hermoso 45) drew with Atalanta 1 (Krstovic 12); Udinese 0 lost to Parma 1 (Elphege 51).

Bundesliga: Eintracht Frankfurt 1 (Larsson 34) lost to RB Leipzig 3 (Diomande 27, Nusa 70, Harder 81).



Aggressive: Shafali gave India a solid start in her 100th T20I but it was not enough. BCCI.TV

SA consigns India to a
second straight defeat

INDIA IN SA

Press Trust of India
DURBAN

Laura Wolvaardt made a free-flowing 54 and Sune Luus complemented her skipper with a well-composed 57 as South Africa crushed India by eight wickets in the second women’s T20I on Sunday.

Earlier, India was bundled for a below-par 147 before Wolvaardt and Luus added 106 for the opening stand in just 12 overs during the chase. South Africa now leads the five-match series 2-0.

Wolvaardt reached her fifty, 15th in a stellar T20I career so far, off just 30 balls. At the other end, Luus was more patient, working spinners around for singles and twos with occasional boundaries.

Shreyanka, however, got rid of both of them, but it came too late to alter the course of the match.

Earlier, opener Shafali Verma struck a typically aggressive 57 in her 100th T20I but the rest struggled against a largely accurate South Africa attack. Shafali was involved in a fine stand

of 53 with debutant Anushka Sharma (28) but it was not a smooth stay by any stretch of imagination.

After losing Smriti Mandhana and Jemimah Rodrigues in successive overs of left-arm spinner Chloe Tryon, India mounted a comeback through Shafali and Anushka.

But taking a cue from their spinners, pacers Ayabonga Khaka, Tumi Sekhukhune and Nadine de Klerk mixed cutters and slow balls to keep the Indian batters guessing.

Shafali fell skying Noku Mlaba to De Klerk in the deep. A little bit earlier, Tryon ousted Anushka as India slipped to 109 for four. Skipper Harmanpreet Kaur, Richa Ghosh and Deepti Sharma all fell trying to accelerate. In fact, India lost eight wickets for a mere 48 runs in that period of disarray.

The scores:

India 147 in 20 overs (Shafali Verma 57, Anushka Sharma 28, Tumi Sekhukhune 3/31, Chloe Tryon 3/22) lost to South Africa 148/2 in 17.1 overs (Laura Wolvaardt 54, Sune Luus 57, Shreyanka Patil 2/35). Toss: South Africa; PoM: Tryon. South Africa won by eight wickets and leads the five-match series 2-0.

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M CH-CHE

R. Kaushik

Imagine life without change. Without progress, without improvements, without moving on from the yesterday. Imagine being trapped in a time warp, waking up to the same things every day, going through a rigmarole that comes with the regularity of sunrise and sunset.

Imagine if, nearly 150 years after the first Test match, cricket remained a days' game, played with a red ball, on uncovered surfaces. Impossible, right? Especially for those weaned on a steady - overwhelming? - diet of 20-over cricket, the five-day game might not appeal entirely with its subtle ebbs and flows rather than in-your-face, outlandish exhibitions of skill and athleticism. For generations together, international cricket meant only the red-ball version, until limited-overs internationals were born almost out of compulsion, if you like.

England's men were in Australia for their quadrennial sojourn to battle it for the Ashes in the (Antipodean) summer of 1970-71 when the third Test at the magnificent Melbourne Cricket Ground had to be abandoned due to incessant rain. To ensure some action during a tour blighted by the elements, a limited-overs international was pencilled in so that the spectators could partake of some entertainment. The match was to be played over 40 (eight-ball) overs a side, on 5 January 1971; Ian Chappell's 60 trumped Player of the Match John Edrich's 82 as Australia breezed home by five wickets. Some four and a half years later, the first men's World Cup was played in England. Eight years thereafter, India produced the most stunning, stirring run to grab their first (and only) 60-over World Cup under Kapil Dev and the cricket world wasn't the same again.

A country that had looked askance as limited-overs play gained popularity in other parts of the world was now hooked to that format, a relationship further solidified in 1985 when Sunil Gavaskar led his unbeaten side to the World Championship of Cricket crown in Melbourne in his final assignment as the national captain. Only the semifinal (against England) and the epochal final (against mighty West Indies) of the 1983 Prudential World Cup were telecast live in India. That was upped to three matches at the WCC – the final league tie against Australia, the semifinal against New Zealand and the needle final against Pakistan at MCG.

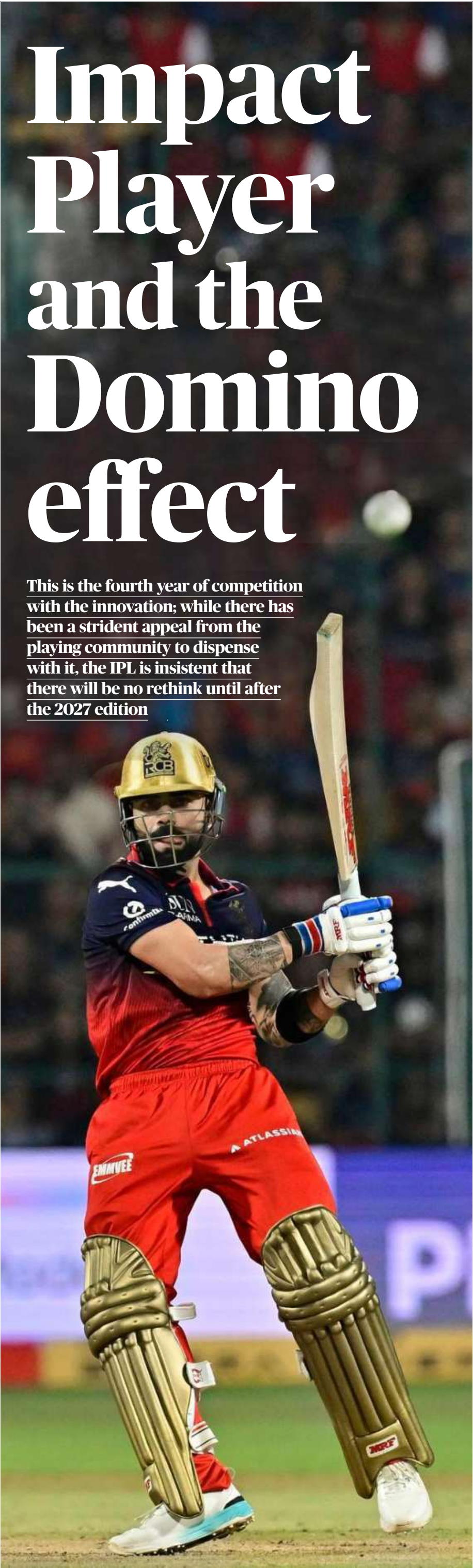
The production quality of those matches transfixed a still fledgling Indian audience. The visuals were spectacular, the analysis top-notch. Indeed, even as Geoff Howarth, the New Zealand captain, was walking back towards the pavilion, run out looking for a second run, the camera zoomed in on his left pad, which had collapsed towards his knee. Howarth, we were educated, had his pads on wrongly. The buckles were on the outside of his left leg, the ball broke one of the three buckles on contact and therefore the pad slid down, hampering his running and resulting in his dismissal. For some reason, more than 41 years on, that slice of action is as fresh in memory as Pakistani's Nairobi-born Qasim Umar using his bat as a rifle to gun down the 'duck' accompanying him on the long walk back to the dressing room after being yorked first ball by a peach from Kapil in the final.

Coloured clothing, white ball, black sightcreens and the Indian outfit clambering on to Champion of Champions Ravi Shastri's Audi formalised India's romance with limited-overs cricket. Further fillip was provided by India and Pakistan jointly staging the 1987 World Cup (now standardised to 50 overs a side) and when the Indian market opened up a couple of years later as liberalisation gained firm root, Test cricket was in danger of being eclipsed by the upstart.

Who knew then that, in a stunning reversal, the 'upstart' would be pushed to a corner by an even more sprightly sibling a decade and a half later. If one-day international cricket was an accidental development, the 20-over version was a deliberate, well-planned, some might say even desperate, attempt to arrest an alarming slide in England, where cricket was shedding audiences by the hundreds over a reasonable period of time.

Seamless mix
One-day games assumed a monotonous hue of regularity and sameness while the county championship failed to retain old faithfuls, let alone attract newer fans. Research indicated the need for a shorter, snappier, more dramatic variant, and thus sprang T20 cricket, more than two decades back. It was an experiment more than anything else, most likely, because desperate times called for desperate measures. The T20 format was packaged as a seamless mix of the sport and of entertainment but one wasn't sure how it would be received. Well, we all know for certain now, don't we?

And therefore, to misquote a popular saying, necessity became the mother of innovation. Soon, India won the inaugural T20 World Cup, the Indian Premier League grabbed the consciousness of the cricketing world and here we are, bang in the middle of the 19th edition of a



K. MURALI KUMAR

tournament that has no parallel when it comes to cricket.

The IPL has grown into a multi-billion-dollar industry without compromising on its core plank, cricket, but it hasn't merely rested on its laurels. From eight teams in 2008, it now has 10 protagonists, but that isn't the only significant change. Each year for the last few years, the intention has been to throw up something new to heighten the excitement stakes, which is how the Impact Player rule came into being ahead of the 2023 edition.

The intention behind introducing that concept wasn't to ramp up the rate of scoring or to boost team totals to the range of 225 and beyond on a consistent basis, actually. When it was first conceptualised, the idea behind the impact player was to allow teams to field an additional specialist bowler, ostensibly to provide a greater balance between scything willow and helpless ball. That it has had the diametrically opposite effect is one of the great ironies that make life so

interesting. And unpredictable.

We are into the fourth year of competition with the Impact Player provision, and while there has been a strident appeal from the currently-playing community to dispense with that option, the IPL is insistent that there will be no rethink until after the 2027 edition. Undoubtedly, the latter decision has been dictated by other commitments because otherwise, why would you ignore the inputs of those who are playing the game, of the captains who have the luxury of summoning an additional option that goes against the basic cricketing tenet of 11 versus 11 but who aren't exactly fans of that 'luxury'?

The Impact Player rule has been used smartly and conveniently because, well, that's the whole idea, isn't it? Sometimes, it has given ponderous movers and unsafe catchers the license to just play as batters and tear bowling attacks apart. At others, it has facilitated those less than fully fit

from using this to focus on their primary suit while bidding their team and waiting for a full recovery, such as happened with Sanju Samson at the start of last season when he was cleared to bat but not keep for Rajasthan Royals. Or, last week, with Virat Kohli.

From the time he committed to being the best physical version of himself sometime in 2013, Kohli has been the benchmark when it comes to looking after his body, when it comes to professionalism. Even when his bat went cold and his quest for an international century ran beyond a whopping 1,000 days, there was no compromise on attention to fitness. Kohli was the catalyst of a fitness revolution in Indian cricket because he didn't just command that facet, he demanded it when he became the Test captain at the start of 2015. His intensity is scary, and it's a mini miracle that despite having operated at the highest level with that degree of intensity for nearly 18 years, he has assiduously kept burnout at bay.

To those who insist that Kohli is a freak of sorts and therefore should not be the yardstick against which to judge mere mortals, we say agreed, spot-on. But he is the most shining example of his generation, at the very least, of putting mind over matter, of achieving one's goals through clarity of thinking and an unwavering, unalloyed attention to detail that, combined with leaving no stone unturned in continuing to keep polishing one's skills, is a sure-shot recipe for success. Kohli has of course had issues with form, he has grappled with a troublesome back on and off for several years, but none of that has dimmed his fire or diminished his focus one bit.

To see Kohli pencilled in as an Impact Player for Royal Challengers Bengaluru last week, in a home fixture against Lucknow Super Giants, was therefore a bit of a shock to the system of those who have, in an almost backhanded compliment, taken a fit Kohli for granted. Just a few days prior to the LSG clash, Kohli didn't come out to field against Mumbai Indians at the Wankhede. It transpired later that he had been under the weather leading into the contest and was further hampered by a sore knee, which prevented him from fielding when Mumbai began their unsuccessful chase of 241 for an unlikely victory.

As a precautionary measure, and because the rules allowed it, Kohli didn't take the field when LSG batted first at the Chinnaswamy last Wednesday. The sight of Kohli watching on from the dugout as his bowlers ran rings around Rishabh Pant's side was a little disconcerting because that's not the Kohli we are used to. Some of us were debating if RCB should not consider resting Kohli totally, considering they were only chasing a modest 147, but the former captain opened (as impact sub) as per norm alongside Phil Salt and blazed to 49 off 34 before he was dismissed.

Normal service was restored on Saturday when RCB did not 'sub out' Kohli after posting 175 for eight against Delhi Capitals. Clearly, the need for precaution doesn't exist anymore and as soon as he could, Kohli was back out in the middle, prowling the infield, dashing around the outfield and taking a tumbling catch at long-off to pack off birthday boy and local lad, K.L. Rahul.

The showman was in his element; he doesn't address press conferences anymore (he hasn't attended one since September 2022) but if he did, he'd tell us that the dugout isn't his den, impact player rule or not.

THE GIST

▼ The intention behind introducing that concept wasn't to ramp up the rate of scoring or to boost team totals to the range of 225 and beyond on a consistent basis, actually

▼ To see Kohli pencilled in as an impact player for Royal Challengers Bengaluru last week, in a home fixture against Lucknow Super Giants, was therefore a bit of a shock

▼ Normal service was restored on Saturday when RCB did not 'sub out' Kohli after posting 175 for eight against Delhi Capitals. Kohli was back out in the middle, prowling the infield. The showman was in his element

The Impact Player rule has been used smartly and conveniently because, well, that's the whole idea, isn't it? Sometimes, it has given ponderous movers and unsafe catchers the license to just play as batters and tear bowling attacks apart. At others, it has facilitated those less than fully fit from using this to focus on their primary suit while bidding their team and waiting for a full recovery



S CH-CHE

Text & Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Number of makeshift homes destroyed in Malaysia's Sabah

1,000 A huge fire destroyed about 1,000 makeshift homes and displaced thousands of people in a coastal village in Malaysia's Sabah state on Sunday. The blaze broke out early on Sunday in a "water village" in Sandakan district in Sabah's northeast. PTI

Unlawful social media posts acted upon by Election Commission

11,000 The EC said it has taken action against 11,000 "unlawful" social media posts related to the polls. It said that any manipulated content has to be acted upon within three hours of being brought to the notice of the platforms. PTI

Drivers prosecuted for drunk driving in Delhi so far in 2026

7,478 Delhi Traffic Police booked 269 people for drunk driving during a special integrated night checking across the national capital. The three-hour operation was conducted as part of an ongoing campaign against driving under the influence of alcohol. PTI

Artisans trained on the use of AI under PM Vishwakarma scheme

2,500 The Ministry of Micro, Small, and Medium Enterprises on Sunday said over 2,500 beneficiaries have been trained on the use of AI tools under the PM Vishwakarma Scheme to improve their livelihoods and business potential. PTI

Number of complaints received by J&K ACB in the last six years

23,798 According to data provided by the Anti-Corruption Bureau (ACB) in reply to an RTI query, in the last six years, the ACB received a massive volume of 23,798 complaints. PTI
COMPILED BY THE HINDU DATA TEAM

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On delimitation and Parliament seats

What is delimitation, and how does it work in India? What changes were proposed in the 131st Constitutional Amendment Bill? Why was an increase in Lok Sabha seats proposed? What concerns did the Opposition raise against the Bills? What is the way forward?

EXPLAINER

Rangarajan R.

The story so far:

The Union government had introduced the Constitution (131st Amendment) Bill to increase the maximum number of Lok Sabha seats from the existing 550 to 850. It had also introduced a Bill to set up the Delimitation Commission in 2026. However, the Constitution Amendment Bill was defeated in the Lok Sabha, and thereafter, the Delimitation Bill was withdrawn by the government.

What are the existing provisions?

Delimitation refers to the process of fixing the number of seats and the boundaries of territorial constituencies in each State for the Lok Sabha and Legislative Assemblies. This exercise is carried out by a Delimitation Commission set up through an Act of Parliament. Such exercises have previously been conducted based on the 1951, 1961, and 1971 Censuses. The number of Lok Sabha seats, based on the 1971 Census, was fixed at 543 when the population was 54.8 crore. The number has been frozen, based on the 1971 Census, to encourage population control measures. As per the current constitutional provisions, this number is to be readjusted based on the 2027 Census.

In 2023, through the 106th Constitutional Amendment, Parliament provided for one-third reservation of seats for women in the Lok Sabha and State Legislative Assemblies. This would be through delimitation based on the next Census.

What are the Bills?

The 131st Constitution Amendment Bill proposed three key changes. First, to



The Bill proposed to increase the maximum number of Lok Sabha seats from 550 to 850. PTI

increase the maximum number of Lok Sabha seats from 550 to 850. Second, to empower Parliament to determine the Census based on which delimitation would be carried out. Third, to delink one-third reservation for women from the next Census in 2027 and to enable the same based on delimitation as per the last published Census of 2011.

The Delimitation Bill, 2026, provided for the setting up of a Delimitation Commission from time to time by the Union government. This Commission would allocate Lok Sabha seats among the States and Union Territories based on the latest Census figures. Had the Bill been passed and a Commission immediately constituted, the allocation would have been based on the 2011 Census.

What are the issues?

The government argued that increasing the number of Lok Sabha seats by around 50% (from 543 to 816) would enable the seamless implementation of one-third

reservation for women in an expanded House. This would have resulted in approximately 272 seats being reserved for women.

Union Home Minister Amit Shah gave an oral assurance that the number of seats in each State and Union Territory would be increased by 50% on a pro-rata basis, thereby not altering the current proportion of their representation in the total strength of the Lok Sabha.

However, the Opposition raised several objections. Firstly, there was no need to bundle women's reservations with delimitation. The 106th amendment in 2023 enables one-third reservation for women within the existing 543 seats. Second, the draft Bills did not contain an explicit provision for a pro-rata 50% increase in seats for each State or Union Territory. In fact, the Delimitation Bill provided that the allocation of seats would be as per the latest Census population. Third, the Opposition contended that such an important and

sensitive subject requires detailed discussions and should not be rushed through in a brief session.

What can be the way forward?

Democracy implies government by the people. It follows that the government is elected by the majority with the broad principle of 'one citizen-one vote-one value'. This principle has been diluted in the interest of population control since 1976, when the delimitation exercise was frozen based on the 1971 Census. Given the federal nature of India's polity, the next delimitation process has to take into consideration the variation in population growth across States.

Mr. Shah offered to include an explicit provision to guarantee a 50% pro-rata increase in seats for each State and Union Territory. It was unclear whether this would have been provided in the Constitution Amendment or the Delimitation Bill. If it had been provided in the Constitutional Amendment, any future changes for the same could have been effected only by a two-thirds majority. However, if it had been provided in the Delimitation Bill, amendments could be made by a simple majority.

Article 81(2) of the Constitution provides that the ratio between the number of seats and the population of each State should, as far as practicable, be the same across States. While a 50% pro-rata increase may offer a middle ground between democratic and federal principles, it would still be appropriate to discuss the same in more detail through parliamentary committees. The other urgent reform needed in our democracy is to empower the local bodies of Panchayats and Municipalities, which engage with the citizens on a daily basis. (Rangarajan R. is a former IAS officer and author of 'Polity Simplified'. He currently trains civil-service aspirants at 'Officers IAS Academy'. Views expressed are personal)

THE GIST

The proposed increase in Lok Sabha seats and changes to delimitation faced political opposition and were defeated in Parliament.

The core issue remains balancing "one citizen-one vote-one value" with federal concerns, requiring wider consensus and detailed parliamentary scrutiny.

What does U.P's minimum wage revision change?

How does the new wage structure balance worker welfare and industrial stability?

Vikram Karuna

The story so far:

The Uttar Pradesh government issued a crucial notification on April 17, in regard to the revision of minimum wages in the State as an interim step, with retrospective effect from April 1, 2026. This move comes in the backdrop of labour unrest in industrial areas such as Noida and Ghaziabad.

These incidents were not isolated, highlighting concerns of wage stagnation, rising cost of living, and disparities in wages when compared with other industrialised States. In response, the State government established a High-Level Committee comprising senior officers, worker representatives and employers from industrial zones. The committee's consultations and suggestions provided the basis of the notification.

What are the key features of the notification?

The notification revises existing minimum wage rates under the Minimum Wages Act, 1948, using powers under the United

Provinces Industrial Disputes Act, 1947. An important provision is the division of the State into three categories, depending upon geographical and economic factors.

Gautam Buddha Nagar and Ghaziabad are categorised as Category I due to their being areas where industrial activity is concentrated and the cost of living. Category II encompasses districts with municipal corporations, while Category III contains the rest. In each case, wages are set based on skill levels – unskilled, semi-skilled, and skilled. The wage structure comprises a basic amount and a Variable Dearness Allowance (VDA). For example, in Category I, monthly wages are fixed at ₹13,690 for unskilled labour, ₹15,059 for semi-skilled labour, and ₹16,868 for skilled labour. The same rates apply for Categories II and III, but with some reduction in the amount of wages paid in the latter cases.

The introduction of the Variable Dearness Allowance ensures the flexibility of wages against any inflationary pressure, while the revision of the basic wage rate corrects structural deficiencies in wages.

Notably, the rates specified in the notice are interim in nature.

What is the legal and economic basis for wage determination?

The determination of minimum wages in the State of Uttar Pradesh involves statutory considerations that blend legal requirements with economic factors. Under the Minimum Wages Act, minimum wages are reviewed periodically, taking into account the All-India Consumer Price Index (CPI). The Variable Dearness Allowance is directly tied to fluctuations in CPI, ensuring that real wages do not lose value due to inflation.

The 2026 notification underscores a key challenge: delays in wage revisions that ought to be conducted at regular intervals. The minimum wages were supposed to be revised based on the averages of CPI in 2017 and 2023 during 2019 and 2024, respectively; however, this did not happen, leading to a widening gap between actual wages and inflation-adjusted wage levels.

The CPI, for instance, increased to an average of 425 by 2025 when compared to the previous index of 216. In other words, the present revision is aimed at responding to current economic realities while simultaneously rectifying a

long-standing problem that occurred in previous years. The framework also finds its place in the larger scheme of the Code on Wages, 2019. While it is true that the Code on Wages aims to update and modernise wage regulations in India, it provides legal support to the existing tri-level categorisation of minimum wages. It gives State governments the authority to fix differential minimum wages, taking into consideration regional variations, cost of living, and type of employment. Furthermore, a national floor wage system is planned to be introduced in the future, which would enable wage harmonisation across States.

What are the implications?

The implications of such a revision are numerous and diverse. Firstly, for workers in the industrial cluster, it offers partial relief by improving incomes and easing cost-of-living pressures, though questions remain on whether it meets the standard of a living wage. Secondly, the revision involves increasing labour costs for employers, potentially resulting in loss of profits. Thirdly, for the State, the key challenge lies in effective implementation, which might prove rather problematic considering the existence of informal sectors with weak regulation.

Since the notification is interim, further reforms are expected, including the establishment of the Wage Board and State rules under the Code on Wages. However, further actions are needed, including the creation of an effective wage system based on solid data. (Vikram Karuna is an Assistant Professor at the School of Law, Justice & Governance, Gautam Buddha University, Greater Noida)

THE GIST

The Uttar Pradesh government issued an interim notification revising minimum wages in response to worker disturbances, wage stagnation, and rising cost of living, based on recommendations of a High-Level Committee.

The new wage structure, linked to the Consumer Price Index through Variable Dearness Allowance, seeks to correct delays in wage revision while balancing worker relief, employer costs, and implementation challenges.

Here is a quiz on the United Nations and global governance

*He was warned
for running
his mouth off*